

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Skillful Means

Ārya-Upāyakauśalya-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 261 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཐབས་མཁས་པ་ཞེས་བུ་བྱ་བཞེ་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛོད་

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Skillful Means, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Upāyakauśalya-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa thabs mkhas pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a Mahāyāna sūtra devoted to the theme of skillful means, the Buddha's capacity to adapt his teachings and conduct to the needs and conditions of beings. The text opens with the Buddha dwelling at Śrāvastī amid an enormous assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, setting the stage for teachings that explore how compassionate wisdom may express itself through seemingly unconventional or even transgressive actions for the ultimate benefit of others. It is catalogued as Toh 261 in the Kangyur, the collection of canonical texts attributed to the Buddha himself, and belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras.

Translated and established as a definitive text.

In the language of India: Ārya-Upāyakauśalya-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Skillful Means.

First fascicle.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One (the Buddha) was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, in the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of eighty-four thousand monks. He was also accompanied by sixty-six thousand bodhisattvas great beings — those possessed of higher knowledge (abhijñā), who had attained dhāraṇī, who had eloquence, and who were unobstructed.

At that time the Blessed One arose from inner meditative equipoise, and, with a great retinue of many hundreds of thousands surrounding and facing him, he taught the Dharma. At that time a bodhisattva great being named Jñānottara came to that assembly and took his seat.

Then the bodhisattva great being Jñānottara draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, pressing his palms together in salutation toward the Blessed One, addressed the Blessed One in

these words: "If the Blessed One would grant me the opportunity to make a request, so that having asked I may receive a prophecy, I would ask the Blessed One something on one topic."

When he had spoken these words, the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva great being Jñānottara: "Son of good family, ask the Tathāgata whatever you wish. Having asked, I shall satisfy your mind with that very prophecy, whatever it may be." Having so declared, the bodhisattva Jñānottara addressed the Blessed One in these words:

"Blessed One, what is the skillful means (upāya) of bodhisattvas great beings — that which is called 'skillful means'?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva great being Jñānottara:

"Son of good family, the skillful means of a bodhisattva great being is this: with even a single morsel of food, one pervades all sentient beings. Why is that? Son of good family, when a bodhisattva great being, skilled in means, gives a single morsel of food to one belonging to the animal realm, that act is itself accompanied by the mind of omniscience, and that root of virtue is then dedicated to all sentient beings. By two causes, then, one pervades all sentient beings. What are those two? The mind of omniscience, and dedication of merit.

"Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva great being skilled in means rejoices in the roots of virtue of others. Having so rejoiced, he dedicates them to all sentient beings. Giving with that mind of omniscience, he surpasses even those who are themselves the donors, and he also surpasses those who are the recipients.

"Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means takes all the flowers that have grown from trees throughout the ten directions — those tiny blossoms not yet gathered up — and all the fragrant woods of the ten directions carried by the wind, ownerless and yet uncollected, and offers them all to every buddha. That root of virtue too he dedicates to omniscience.

"Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means contemplates all the pleasant feelings experienced by whatever sentient beings there are throughout the ten directions, and rejoices in every one of them."

He rejoices in all of these and dedicates them to omniscience. And whatever painful feelings are experienced by sentient beings throughout the ten

directions — all of these he takes upon himself, entering into them with the wish: "May the suffering of those sentient beings come to me, and may they be happy." Donning such armor, he dedicates that root of virtue as well to awakening.

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means, when paying homage to a single Tathāgata, regards it as paying homage to all Tathāgatas, and he trains in this as follows: "All buddhas share one dharmadhātu, one moral discipline, one meditative absorption, one wisdom, one intention, one liberation, and one gnosis that sees liberation." Trained thus, when he pays homage to one Tathāgata, he holds it to be homage paid to all Tathāgatas. This one skilled in means, by showing reverence to a single buddha, shows reverence to all buddhas, and fully appropriates for himself all the offerings that exist for those buddhas of the ten directions.

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means, even at a time when he finds himself dim in wisdom, does not disparage himself, but rather praises himself, thinking: "Even if I am small, if I recite a single verse on one of the four bases, then the meaning of that single verse on a base is identical to the meaning of all that belongs to the scriptural canon." He thus trains in this way, and after reciting that verse, he makes an aspiration with an undaunted mind: "May all the sentient beings, however many, who hear this verse on a base recited by me, thereby attain the confidence of a buddha." By that root of virtue, he surpasses the measureless, incomparable hearing of all sentient beings, and he also acquires the confidence of a buddha.

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means, if at some time he becomes utterly destitute, then even from his youth, having worked for others and obtained whatever morsel of food he can carry, he gives it without a downcast mind to the Saṅgha or to an individual. After giving, he trains in this way, reflecting: "The Blessed One taught that generosity becomes great through greatness of mind. Although my giving is small, my mind of omniscience is immeasurable." With that mind of omniscience, he gives whatever morsel of food he has, and with that very morsel — through the nature of generosity, the nature of moral discipline, and the nature of meditation — he brings about the basis of meritorious action, making the aspiration: "By this root of virtue, may all sentient beings become like the present Tathāgata, the Jewel-Handed One."

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means, even when dwelling together with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, does not wish to be like them. Yet if he sees them being paid reverence, he inwardly assimilates this through two reasons. And what are those two reasons? It is from bodhisattvas that the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, arise, and from the buddhas that the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas arise; therefore, when reverence is paid to them, it is, in the first place, reverence paid to oneself alone, and not to them. And moreover, he reflects: "They are enjoying what is my father's wealth, yet I should not wish for it back, nor should I be envious."

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means, when practicing generosity, brings all six perfections to complete fulfillment. And how does he bring them to complete fulfillment?

In this regard, whenever a bodhisattva sees a beggar, he cuts through the mind of miserliness and causes great generosity to increase — that is his perfection of generosity.

When he has properly taken up moral discipline and gives to those who are endowed with moral discipline, and also establishes those who are of poor conduct in moral discipline while giving to them as well — that is his perfection of moral discipline.

When he gives with a mind of loving-kindness, with an unagitated mind, with a mind of benevolence, and with a mind that has become one-pointed — that is his perfection of patience.

When he applies body, speech, and mind to those things that are to be eaten, worn, and enjoyed, and goes forth and returns for their sake — that is his perfection of diligence.

After giving, whatever is one-pointed and does not grasp at relief — that is his perfection of meditative concentration.

If, after making that gift, one rests in the nature of reality and reflects thus: "By whom was this given? By whom was it consumed? For whom will the karmic ripening occur?" — and in so reflecting finds no phenomenon whatsoever to be apprehended as the giver, as the recipient, or as the one who will experience the ripening — that is his perfection of wisdom.

Thus, son of good family, it is in this way that a bodhisattva skilled in means, when practicing generosity, brings all six perfections to complete fulfillment.

Then the bodhisattva Jñānottara addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, it is wondrous that this very generosity by which the bodhisattva, the great being, through such skillful means causes other sentient beings to take up cyclic existence in full, is the same generosity by which he takes up the qualities of a buddha."

The Blessed One declared: "It is exactly so, son of good family — it is just as you have said. A bodhisattva skilled in means makes even a small act of generosity into something great, and makes even a great act of generosity into something immeasurable."

Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, the great being, Jñānottara: "Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva skilled in means makes even a grave transgression light through skillful means. And how does he make it light? Son of good family, in this regard: if at some time a bodhisattva skilled in means incurs a transgression under the influence of an evil companion, he trains himself thus: 'If I were to pass into nirvāṇa by means of these very aggregates, my mind would become utterly tormented. But since I have donned such armor — the armor of remaining in cyclic existence until the very end, for the sake of bringing sentient beings to full maturity — I must not allow my mind to be tormented. However deeply I continue to move through cyclic existence, to that same degree I shall bring sentient beings to full maturity. As for this transgression, I shall deal with it according to the Dharma. And I shall take care that no further transgression arises.' Son of good family, if one takes up this comprehensive examination, I declare that even if an ordained bodhisattva were to transgress all four root downfalls, this skillful means would purify him, and it would not constitute a bodhisattva's downfall."

Then the bodhisattva Jñānottara addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, in what way does a bodhisattva incur a downfall?"

When this was asked, the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being, Jñānottara: "Son of good family, when a bodhisattva is training in the prātimokṣa (the code of individual liberation) training, he may eat the root and fruit for even a thousand aeons, and all sentient beings may speak well of him,

and may also endure those who speak ill of him, and may also maintain the aspiration of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — this is a weighty root downfall for a bodhisattva. Son of good family, consider this example: just as one who dwells in the śrāvaka vehicle, should a root downfall occur, has no fortune to

pass beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa in that very body, so too, son of good family, if a bodhisattva does not confess a downfall and does not relinquish the aspiration of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, he has no fortune to pass beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa at the stage of buddhahood.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as I was going on alms-round in due order, I saw the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha sitting together with a woman on a single seat in a certain house. When you see a downfall occurring, you said, do not cover it up, but report it to others who practice pure conduct. Since the Tathāgata is the Teacher of all sentient beings, and there is nothing whatsoever unknown to the Tathāgata, unseen by him, or uncomprehended by him, it is for that reason that I report this to the Blessed One." Having spoken these words, the venerable Ānanda had not long finished speaking when, at that very moment, the earth trembled.

Then the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha, seated in the mid-air at the height of a tāla tree, said to the venerable Ānanda: "Venerable Ānanda, what do you think? Is one who is subject to downfalls capable of sitting in mid-air? Moreover, venerable Ānanda, ask this Tathāgata, who is present here directly before you, what the nature of a bodhisattva's downfall is like." Then the venerable Ānanda, filled with remorse, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One and said: "A transgression that I have committed — Blessed One, I have erred in seeking a downfall in a great being as noble as a bull elephant. I have erred; I confess the error." When he had spoken these words, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, do not conceive of wrongdoing toward a holy person who dwells in the Great Vehicle. Ānanda, consider this: one who dwells alone in the śrāvaka vehicle should be regarded as striving without obstacle toward the exhaustion of defilements. Just so, Ānanda, a bodhisattva who possesses skillful means should be regarded as striving without obstacle toward omniscience. And why? Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not deceive those who, unwaveringly devoted to the Three Jewels, would not come to fall away from them. What are the Three Jewels? The Jewel of the Buddha, the Jewel of the Dharma, and the Jewel of the Saṅgha. Ānanda, when you see a son of good family who dwells in the bodhisattva vehicle, who, never separated from the mind of omniscience, delights and engages fully in the five qualities of the desire realm, at that time, Ānanda, you should know that holy person to be endowed with the five faculties of a Tathāgata. Ānanda, now listen to why the bodhisattva King

Prabhāvyūha was sitting together with a woman on a single seat. Ānanda, that woman, in a past time spanning two hundred lifetimes, was the wife of the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha. Through the force of those former habitual tendencies, son of good family, upon beholding the glory, the splendor, the moral discipline, and the strength of the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha, affliction arose in her and she spoke words of improper conduct.

She went off alone in secret, thinking to herself: "If the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha were to sit with me together on a single seat, I would arouse the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening." And so she resolved within herself in just that way.

Ānanda, the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha then discerned through his own mind the full scope of that sister's mental intention, and that very same evening, when the night had passed, he came to her house. With a mind unified in the Dharma-door that makes the inner earth element and the outer earth element one and the same, he took that sister by the right hand and sat with her upon a single seat. The very moment they were seated, he spoke these verses:

Buddhas do not praise the pursuit of desire.
That is the domain of the childish.
One who has abandoned craving for desire
becomes a buddha, supreme among humans.

Ānanda, thereupon that sister felt joy and delight arise within her. She rose from the seat, prostrated at the feet of the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha, and in that very moment spoke these verses:

What the buddhas reproach —
desire I shall no longer seek.
One who has abandoned craving for desire
becomes a buddha, supreme among humans.
The transgression conceived in my mind
I now confess before you.
For the happiness of all living beings
I have aroused devotion toward awakening.

Ānanda, it was just so: the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha, through the power of his skillful means, trained that sister in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and then rose from his seat and departed.

Ānanda, look to the distinction of heightened intention. I gave that sister a prophecy: "Departing from this life, she will exchange her female body, and after ninety-nine hundred thousand countless eons she will appear in the world as the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha named Free from All Agitation." Ānanda, you should know by this account as well that a bodhisattva does not take on servants who are of a nature subject to downfall.

Then the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha descended from that intermediate space, prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One, and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, a bodhisattva dwells in skillful means and in great compassion. Blessed One, this is what I think: if a bodhisattva can plant a root of virtue in even a single sentient being, and if in doing so a transgression of that kind arises — and if on account of such a transgression arising he were to be cooked in the hell of sentient beings for a hundred thousand eons — Blessed One, the bodhisattva would still rejoice in that transgression arising and in those sufferings of the hells. He would never give up or diminish the root of virtue planted in even that single sentient being."

Then the Blessed One gave the word "Excellent!" to the bodhisattva King Prabhāvyūha and declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble beings — bodhisattvas — through this very great compassion relinquish all transgressions. Son of good family, through my direct knowledge I know that beyond the far side of incalculable eons of the past, there was a young man named Tāraka. He practised the holy life at the edge of a forest for forty-two thousand years, and when those forty-two thousand years had passed, he went to the royal palace called Samṛddha and entered that great city. A water-seller woman saw that fine young man and, her mind seized entirely by sensuous desire, she ran up before that youth and prostrated to him. Then, son of good family, the young man Tāraka said to that woman: 'Sister, what do you want?' And she replied to him:

"Young man, I desire you." He said to her: "Sister, I have no need of sensuous desire." She replied to him: "If I cannot be united with you, I shall die." Then the young man Tāraka thought to himself: "It is not fitting for me to break the vows of discipline I have maintained through forty-two thousand years of the holy life." He firmly pulled himself away, and when the woman released him and he had taken seven steps forward, he stopped at that seventh step and compassion arose in him. He thought: "Even if I break these vows and go to the hells as a result, I can endure the suffering of the hells — let this woman be free from harm and dwell in happiness." And so, son of good family, the

young man Tāraka turned back, took that woman by his right hand, and said: "Sister, do whatever you desire." Thereafter the young man Tāraka dwelt in the household for twelve years, and then once again he went forth, cultivated the four divine abidings (brahmavihāras), died and was transferred, and was reborn in the Brahmā world.

Son of good family, do not think that the young man named Tāraka at that time and in that moment was someone other than me. For at that time and in that moment I myself was that young man Tāraka, and Gragdzin-ma (the water-seller woman) was she who is now called Śrāddhinā. Son of good family, through generating the mind of great compassion even while tainted by base desire, I turned away from and abandoned cyclic existence for the span of ten thousand eons.

Son of good family, consider this: where other sentient beings would be reborn in the hells, the bodhisattva who is skilled in means is reborn in the Brahmā world. Son of good family, had the monks Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana's son been endowed with skillful means, the monk Kokālika would not have gone to the hells. Why is that? Son of good family, through my direct knowledge I know that in a past time there appeared a scripture called the Discourse Removing Wrong Faith in the Tathāgatas, and in connection with it there was a monk named Nirmala. While he was staying in a cave in a solitary forest, not far away there dwelt five sages. At that time, an unseasonable great cloud arose and heavy unseasonable rain fell heavily. Two women then entered the cave of the monk Nirmala to take shelter from the rain, and after some time they left. The sages saw this and thought: "How remarkable — this monk Nirmala is a sinful one, one who does not live the holy life!" And their minds became disturbed. Then the monk Nirmala, reading the full range of thoughts in the minds of those sages, rose up into the sky to the height of seven palm trees. When the sages saw the monk Nirmala sitting in the open sky above them, they thought: "According to our own scriptural tradition, one who does not live the holy life cannot rise into the sky." And at that moment they prostrated with five limbs and confessed their fault.

Son of good family, had the monk Nirmala not risen into the sky, the bodies of those five sages would have fallen into the great hells. Son of good family, what do you think? Do not think that the monk named Nirmala at that time and in that moment was someone other. The bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-kindness) was at that time the monk called Nirmala. Son of good family, had the monks Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana's son possessed skillful

means and risen into the sky, the monk Kokālika would likewise not have gone to the hells.

Son of good family, by these synonyms and categories, know that the wisdom of the bodhisattva skilled in means, wherever it reaches, is not within the domain of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Son of good family, consider this: a courtesan endowed with sixty-four arts, who is exceedingly clever and desires wealth — so long as she has not yet obtained wealth from a certain man, she remains in that man's company in whatever way is needed, showing even the willingness to give up her own body and concealing nothing of her possessions. But afterward, once she has obtained what she sought, she discards him, looking at him no longer and thinking of him no more, and feels no remorse toward him thereafter.

Son of good family, in just the same way, the bodhisattva skilled in means — knowing by his skillful means that he must ripen these sentient beings — remains in the company of those sentient beings in whatever manner is needed, delighting in their virtuous roots and not concealing even the slightest thing, showing even the willingness to give up his own body. But the moment he recognizes, "Ah, these sentient beings have now generated virtuous roots, and I am no longer able to nurture them further beyond this point," he looks at them no more, abandons all delight and play, and departs. He retains no mind of attachment toward them.

Son of good family, consider this further: a creature of the animal realm called a bee — though it savors the fragrance of all flowers — does not for that reason cultivate a constant craving to remain anywhere. Nor does it plunder the fragrance or the petals. Likewise, the bodhisattva skilled in means, though he engages in all the pleasures and play of desire, does not for that reason generate constant craving anywhere, nor does he cause harm to himself or others.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a seed that has been thoroughly scorched cannot produce a sprout, though it may retain its color. Son of good family, in just the same way, one who has thoroughly cultivated the wisdom of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness — even while engaging in all pleasures and play — will not on that account incur a downfall through the afflictions, nor will he suffer any diminishment of the qualities of buddhahood.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a fisherman who is thoroughly skilled attaches bait to a single line, lowers it into a great ocean, and whenever

he wishes, he draws that line up from the great ocean. Son of good family, in just the same way, the bodhisattva skilled in means, with a mind that has thoroughly cultivated emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, securely tethers that mind to omniscience itself, and then plunges into the great swamp of desire. Sustained by that mind directed toward omniscience, whenever he so wishes he passes away and is reborn in the Brahma world.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a man who is a master of mantra-knowledge is seized by a king and bound tightly with five bonds. Yet whenever he wishes to go free, by rousing the power of his mantra-knowledge alone he cuts through all his bonds and departs. In just the same way, the bodhisattva skilled in means — even when he is experiencing and absorbed in the pleasure of the five qualities of desire — whenever he so wishes, rouses that single mind of omniscience empowered by the knowledge of wisdom, thoroughly vanquishes all the qualities of desire, passes away, and is reborn in the Brahma world.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a master of archery and weapons, drawing a single sharp sword unseen, removes the pain of many wounds. Among those sentient beings who do not recognize what he is doing, they say of that archery master, "This man has neither bow

nor any other weapon, nor even an attendant. This man cannot even protect himself — what need is there to speak of guiding others? How could he ever prevail over wild men? He will come to grief in those circumstances without good reason." And so the archery master cultivates compassion for them.

Then that master of archery and weapons goes out into the middle of a wilderness. When a great many wild men appear, he dons fine armor against their arrows and weapons, examines that weapon carefully, and lets fly at those wild men. He thereby deprives every one of those wild men of life, and then lays that weapon to rest in his hand once more.

In the same way, son of good family, the bodhisattva, the great being, taking up the supremely sharp weapon of the Perfection of Wisdom, and skilled in means, experiences and revels in the five qualities of desire. Those who see his physical sense faculties generate lack of faith and think: "This one dwells in such heedlessness — he cannot even liberate himself, let alone other sentient beings. How could he ever prevail over māra?" And so they give rise to compassion for him. Yet that bodhisattva, having thoroughly taken up the mastery of skillful means, cuts through the web of afflictions with the sword of

wisdom whenever he so wishes, and departs to a purified buddha field free of women and free of indulgence.

Now at that very time, a bodhisattva named Joyful (Skt. Pramuditā) goes into the great city of Śrāvastī for alms. While wandering for alms he comes to a householder's home, and at that moment a girl named Supreme Merit, who is seated on an upper story, hears the sound of a monk and takes up food, going to where the bodhisattva Joyful is.

As soon as the girl Supreme Merit sees him, from his voice and appearance she seizes upon a sign by which she comes to recognize him, and, her mind completely seized by attachment and tormented by desire, she faints bodily even as she stands, and at the moment of death the bodhisattva Joyful sees the girl Supreme Merit. A conception arises in him as an improper mental engagement characterized by a mind of attachment, and then the thought occurs to him: "What is this phenomenon called attachment?" He reflects: "Is it the eye that is attached? The eye too has no feeling, is without agency, is conditioned, is a heap of flesh — it has no feeling because it is empty by intrinsic nature." "Then is it the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, or the mind that is attached?" He discerns no phenomenon at all, whether internal or external, that could become attachment or become aversion.

Having discerned none, he dispels that mind of attachment and examines her body from the soles of her feet, covered in skin and flesh, all the way up to the crown of her head. Having examined her correctly and just as she is, he realizes that all phenomena are unborn, and thereby attains the patient acceptance (Skt. kṣānti) of the unborn nature of phenomena. Then, filled with joy and delight, he rises into the sky above to the height of a tāla palm tree, circumambulates the great city of Śrāvastī seven times, and goes to where the Blessed One is. The Blessed One sees the bodhisattva Joyful coming through the sky above, unimpeded like a king among geese.

Having seen this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, did you see the bodhisattva, the great being Joyful, coming through the sky?"

He replied: "Blessed One, I did see him."

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, that bodhisattva Joyful thoroughly examined all phenomena from within a mind of attachment. He has tamed the hosts of māra."

He turned the wheel of Dharma. Then the girl Supreme Merit, having just died, was transformed out of a woman's body. Upon dying and passing on, she was born into the realm of the higher worlds with an equal share among the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. The very instant she was born, there arose a magnificent jeweled palace of seven kinds of precious substances, twelve leagues in extent, and forty-four thousand divine maidens were also born to serve as her retinue. At that moment she knew: "By what root of virtue have I come to be born here?" Reflecting on this, she thought: "I was born as the daughter of a householder in the great city of Śrāvastī. There, seeing the bodhisattva Joyful and arousing a mind of attachment toward him, my mind was utterly tormented by the clinging of desire, and when my time of death came, I was transformed out of a woman's body. Having obtained a male body, I have now attained these immeasurable supernatural powers."

Then that divine youth thought: "If even this is the karmic ripening of a mind of attachment, what need is there to speak of bowing down and paying honor to the bodhisattva Joyful? As for sporting with him or delighting him — that would not be fitting. Therefore I shall go to where the Blessed One is, and to where Joyful is."

And so that divine youth, together with his retinue, took up flowers, incense, garlands, and unguents, and set out toward where the Blessed One was, blazing with immeasurable splendor. Having made offerings to the Blessed One with those flowers, garlands, and unguents, he bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and then, standing in the presence of the Blessed One with palms joined, spoke these verses:

The foremost among humans, the buddhas, are inconceivable.
The stations of supreme and exalted awakening are inconceivable.
The dharmas of the Tathāgatas are inconceivable.
The conduct of those of great renown is inconceivable.

I was born as a daughter in Śrāvastī,
the daughter of a merchant, named Supreme Merit,
good and in the prime of youth, full of faith,
with a father and mother who were loving and dear.

Then there came the mighty son of a buddha
who has never reviled a buddha, called Joyful.
When he came to Śrāvastī seeking alms

and entered my father's house,

I heard his agreeable and pleasing voice,
and I, filled with delight, took up the alms-food.
Going to where that mighty son of the Tathāgata,
that Joyful one, was,

the instant I saw him a thought arose in me —
improper, tainted with attachment.
I thought: if my wish is not fulfilled,
I shall not live; my time of death will come.

Unable even to speak a word,
unable to offer that alms-food,
tormented by improper, impassioned attachment,
I collapsed right there and died.

Knowing that my body lay fallen and dead,
my mother and father wept.
My corpse, I understood, lay stretched out there,
and those around me, even the monastics, wept and cried.

Blessed One, the moment after I died and passed on,
I shed that woman's body
and obtained this body of luminous birth.
Having died, I was born into the higher world.

I have obtained this excellent palace,
built of precious substances the like of which no one else possesses.
These fourteen thousand divine maidens
I have gained as my retinue, Blessed One.

At that very moment this thought arose in me:
"How good is this excellent karmic ripening!"
Reflecting thus, I then thought:
"This is the karmic ripening of a mind of attachment.

To Joyful, who delights and pleases and is the maker of light, the learned one
—

When I contemplated with a mind of attachment,
and this was the karmic ripening of that act,
at that moment I became possessed of blazing power —

one who enters into the dance of the Sugata's wisdom.

That which śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas
cannot change even from their own level to another —
if the fruit of a mind of desire is such as this,
what need is there to speak of the honors I would render?

Before the eyes of this Victor,
I aspire to attain the supreme awakening, the buddha's wisdom.
For as many aeons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges,
I will practice and will not abandon my vow.

To the spiritual friend who brings joy and delight,
I shall offer worship vast and far-reaching.
Except for those who lead toward manifest awakening,
to other guides I will make no offering.

Practicing all the noble conduct of awakening,
may those who look upon me with a mind of attachment —
having abandoned the female body —
all become persons born into fearlessness.

Through the power of the Buddha, that son of the gods then went to his father and mother and spoke these words: "Do not feel aversion and anger toward the ascetic — you will come to suffer for a long time! That most excellent one, endowed with supreme merit who has died, is of equal fortune with the Thirty-Three; here too he has exchanged the female body and become a beautiful luminous son of the gods. Go before the Sugata, and confess the fault of that angry mind. Apart from the Buddha, the Tathāgata, there is no other protector and refuge for sentient beings."

Urged on by that fearless one, his father and mother too heard the name of the Buddha. All assembled together, went in company, and arrived before Śākyamuni. They bowed at the feet of that holy man, confessed the fault of their angry minds, took refuge in the Tathāgata, and made a request of the Sugata, the self-arisen one: "How may one make offerings to a guide? And how does one make offerings to the Dharma and the Saṅgha? Please grant a prophecy explaining each of these, and having heard it, we shall go and act accordingly."

The Victor, knowing their minds, spoke true words as the protector of the world: "Whoever wishes to make offerings to all the buddhas should arouse a firm and stable mind directed toward awakening."

The girl's father, mother, and relatives — no fewer than five hundred of them, a complete assembly — heard the words of that foremost of men, and at that very moment they aroused the mind aimed at awakening.

At that time the Blessed One spoke to Ānanda: "Listen, Ānanda, just as I have said: the thought and conduct of a bodhisattva are inconceivable, and so too is the wisdom of skillful means.

The aspiration that Joyful plants for the future — whatever women look upon him with a mind of attachment — may they abandon the female body entirely and be reborn as beings with an expansive mind.

Ānanda, see what the qualities of this one are! Those who send other sentient beings to hell — if they arouse attachment toward those very heroes, may they be born in the higher realms as men. That son of the gods honored me and, with reverence, abided in supreme awakening. Having made offerings to buddhas for many aeons, he will become a Victor called Supremely Seeing. Those five hundred who abide in awakening will also become the highest among humans. Given the immeasurable happiness gained through faith in him, who would not show reverence to the protector?

Those women who looked upon Joyful with a mind of attachment and were reborn having abandoned the female body — not one, or two, or three, but many tens of millions and thousands of myriads — as for that awakening of Joyful, the greatly renowned king of trees, who could produce aversion toward it? If even from afflictions he bestows happiness —

who would then need to be told to show reverence to him?

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, consider this example: whoever approaches the king of mountains, Mount Meru, whether with a mind of faith, a mind of aversion, a mind of attachment, or even a mind that would obstruct the Dharma — all of them, without exception, become a single color, namely the color of gold. Blessed One, in the same way, whoever approaches a bodhisattva — whether with a mind of faith, a mind of aversion, a mind of attachment, or even a mind that would obstruct the Dharma — all of them, without exception, become a single color, namely the color of the mind of omniscience. Blessed One, from

this day forward I shall regard the bodhisattvas as being like Mount Meru.

"Blessed One, consider this further example: there exists a medicinal herb of beautiful form, and whenever any sentient being afflicted by illnesses of various kinds looks upon it, all those illnesses are completely pacified. Blessed One, in the same way, whoever — whether with a mind of faith, a mind of aversion, or a mind of attachment — looks upon a bodhisattva, the illnesses of attachment, aversion, and delusion in all of them are completely pacified."

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the venerable Ānanda, saying "Excellent!" and declared: "Ānanda, it is so. Ānanda, it is exactly as you have said."

Thereupon the venerable Mahākāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, how wonderful! Sugata, how truly wonderful! The bodhisattvas, the great beings, though abiding in the peaceful meditative absorption, out of compassion for sentient beings descend once again even into the desire realm. Dwelling in emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, untouched by the qualities of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, they cause beings to arrive at the mind of omniscience. Blessed One, the bodhisattvas, the great beings, abide in inconceivable skillful means — and this is how it is: though they engage with all forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tangible objects that give rise to attachment, they do not become attached to them.

"Concerning the bodhisattvas, the great beings, I venture to offer a small example, Blessed One, if I may be so bold. Sugata, I am bold to speak.

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, speak boldly."

"Blessed One, consider this: there is a remote wilderness hermitage, and in that hermitage there stands a tower that has risen to the very pinnacle of cyclic existence. In that hermitage there is but a single gate. In that hermitage there are many hundreds and thousands of living creatures. Not far from that wilderness hermitage there is a great city, prosperous, pleasant, and blessed with good harvests, filled with a multitude of people. Those who dwell in that city do not age or die, and the ground of that great city rises to the height of one cubit, and on either side of it there are precipices a hundred thousand forearm-lengths deep. In the middle of that wilderness hermitage there arises a single being who is wise, peaceful, resolute, seeking the good, wishing to benefit others, and desiring prosperity and happiness. That being, addressing the creatures in that hermitage, says: 'Not far from this wilderness hermitage there is a city. Whoever goes there will not age or die.'"

"Come, sentient beings! Come to that great city!" — proclaiming these words with a melodious voice, he called out an invitation to all.

Then those whose aspirations were modest, who were drawn to lesser things, and who wished to set out, said: "Show us that teaching, and we too would like to come to that place — but if it is no greater from here than it is now, then may whatever qualities exist in that city likewise arise right here." And those who aspired to the greater thing said: "We shall come, and just as you are, so too are we" — and with those words they set out together with him. But those of little merit, upon hearing the call, did not believe it.

Then that wise man departed from the wilderness hermitage and came to the road. He saw that the path rose to the height of one cubit, and that on the right side of the path there was a precipice a hundred thousand forearm-lengths deep, and on the left side likewise a precipice a hundred thousand forearm-lengths deep. On both sides of the path he had built a railing to support himself, and by means of these four sides he crossed that raised path, looking neither to the right nor to the left. Though from behind, enemies cried out with terrifying sounds, he did not look back. He had entered the path, and the further he went, the more clearly he saw the great city, and the more he advanced, the more all his fears disappeared. He arrived at that great city and there worked for the benefit of countless sentient beings.

Now, the Blessed One declares: the wilderness hermitage is to be understood as the wilderness hermitage of saṃsāra. The raised path that stretches to the very peak of saṃsāra's summit is to be understood as ignorance, craving, and becoming. The many hundreds and thousands of creatures dwelling in that wilderness hermitage are to be understood as all ordinary beings, who are like children. The single gate is to be understood as the path of the single vehicle. The wise man is to be understood as the bodhisattva, the great being. Those sentient beings of modest aspiration who wish to set out but seek no greater attainment than where they are, and who desire the qualities of the city, are to be understood as śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Those others who said "We shall come, and just as you are, so too are we" are to be understood as bodhisattvas. Those who heard the call but did not believe are to be understood as non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and others. Departing from the wilderness hermitage is to be understood as the diligence dedicated to omniscience. The path raised to the height of one cubit is to be understood as the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. The precipice a hundred

thousand forearm-lengths deep on the right side is to be understood as the ground of śrāvakas. The precipice a hundred thousand forearm-lengths deep on the left side is to be understood as the ground of pratyekabuddhas. The supporting railings built on both sides of the path are to be understood as the diligence endowed with skillful means and the Perfection of Wisdom. Moving forward by means of four sides is to be understood as gathering innumerable and uncountable sentient beings by means of the four means of attraction (Skt. saṃgrahavastu). The enemies behind who display terrifying forms are to be understood as māra and the gods of māra's class — and likewise as the other sentient beings who are unruly, who insult, abuse, and curse the bodhisattvas. Not looking back is a phrase expressing the perfection of patience and the supremacy of intention.

Not looking to the right or left is a phrase expressing the supremacy of the gnosis of omniscience, through not seeking the ground of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Just as the more one sees the city, the more one's fear subsides — this means that just as one sees the qualities of a buddha, and trains in the conduct of a buddha, in gnosis, in the Perfection of Wisdom, and in skillful means, so one proceeds toward sentient beings without fear and without doubt. Arriving at the city and working for the benefit of immeasurable sentient beings — these are phrases expressing the Tathāgata.

The Blessed One said: "A bodhisattva is one endowed with gnosis. Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being."

Then the Blessed One offered praise to the venerable Mahākāśyapa, saying: "Excellent! Excellent, Kāśyapa! Through the similes you have set forth here, twelve thousand living beings — gods and humans — have aroused the mind set on unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening. Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva who abides in skillful means possesses immeasurable qualities. Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva does not engage in actions of the kind that would bring harm to himself or harm to others."

When this had been declared, the bodhisattva Jñānottara addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, how then is it that a bodhisattva who is bound by a single birth, upon seeing this head-touching in the scriptural transmission of the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, would think it sufficient? One might say: 'Ascetic, where is awakening in this mere touching of a head? Awakening is exceedingly rare.' Blessed One, what is the meaning of what was said in those words?"

When this question had been put, the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva Jñānottara: "Son of good family, enough. Do not be troubled about the Tathāgata or about the bodhisattvas. Why? Because a bodhisattva is endowed with inconceivable skillful means. These noble persons abide in whatever way will tame sentient beings, by whatever means. Son of good family, listen very well and hold in mind: I will teach you the enumeration of the Dharma called 'skillful means.' From among the inconceivable skillful means demonstrated up to the time of the Dīpaṃkara by the bodhisattva, only a portion has been shown. Son of good family, from the very moment a bodhisattva sees Dīpaṃkara and attains the patient acceptance of non-arising (Skt. anutpattikadharmakṣānti), there is no confusion in the bodhisattva, no agitation, no failure of mindfulness. Son of good family, a bodhisattva who has attained patient acceptance may, if they wish, attain awakening within seven nights. If they wish, they may attain awakening after one hundred eons in order to bring sentient beings to full maturation. If they take birth again in existence, by generating power through the strength of wisdom, they will attain awakening at whatever time they wish. If they wish, they may remain to the very end of the future without wearying. This is to be understood as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Son of good family, furthermore, a śrāvaka, when they enter into a peaceful meditative absorption just as a bodhisattva enters into a peaceful meditative absorption, holds that absorption to be peaceful — their body unmoving, their mind unmoving — and regards themselves as completely passed beyond sorrow.

A bodhisattva, a great being, upon entering into that peaceful meditative absorption, ripens sentient beings to full maturity and does not abandon diligence in the four means of gathering disciples, nor does he abandon diligence in the six perfections. This too is to be understood as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Son of good family, should a bodhisattva wish, he could attain complete and perfect awakening and turn the wheel of Dharma again while remaining in the Tuṣita heaven. But the people of Jambudvīpa would be unable to travel to a divine palace to hear the Dharma, and so the bodhisattva reflects: "The gods are able to descend to Jambudvīpa to hear the Dharma, but the people of Jambudvīpa are unable to travel to a divine palace to hear the Dharma." For this reason, the bodhisattva attains complete and perfect awakening in Jambudvīpa. This too is to be understood as the skillful means of a

bodhisattva.

Should a bodhisattva wish, he could pass away from Tuṣita and attain complete and perfect awakening in that very instant without entering the dwelling of a mother's womb. But if that were so, some sentient beings would give rise to doubt, thinking: "Is this a god, or a gandharva, or some emanation? Where has this one come from?" Seized by such doubt, they would not listen to the Dharma. For this cause and condition, the bodhisattva displays a sojourn in the womb. This too is to be known as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Son of good family, you should not think of the bodhisattva as having entered the bed of the womb. The bodhisattva has not entered the bed of the womb. Why is that? Because the bodhisattva, having entered into the meditative absorption called the Stainless Absorption of the Bodhisattva, remains at the seat of awakening without having moved. The gods of Tuṣita, for their part, perceive the bodhisattva as having passed away and no longer see him there. Yet the bodhisattva, the great being, does not stir from Tuṣita at all; through emanation he displays all the deeds — entering the womb, being born, going forth from home, performing all the austerities — and all of these are but the emanation of the bodhisattva. Why is that? Because the bodhisattva, living in purity, does not enter the bed of a womb again. This too is to be known as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Then why is it displayed that the bodhisattva transforms into a white elephant calf and enters the mother's womb? White signifies the side of purity. Because the bodhisattva has transcended all sentient beings, it must be shown in just this way that in no respect is he like the gods, nor is he like humans, in his manner of entering. This too is to be known as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

And why does the bodhisattva remain in the mother's womb for ten months rather than nine? Because some sentient beings might think: "Alas, this one has emerged with diminished faculties, having spent an incomplete time in the womb." In order to prevent such a thought, the bodhisattva displays complete and perfect faculties in the womb, and thus he remains for ten months and not nine. This too is to be known as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

And why is the bodhisattva not born in a village or a city, but born in the wilderness? The bodhisattva, from long ago, has praised the remote wilderness in the highest terms and has dwelt in solitude, living in purity. Were

such a one to enter a household, the gods, nāgas, and yakṣas would shower him with divine fragrances, powders, and

flowers continuously without interruption, and the beings of the city — merchants and householders alike — would be exceedingly delighted. For these reasons of cause and condition, the bodhisattva is born in the wilderness.

And why does the bodhisattva enter the womb by passing through the right side of his mother? In order to cut through the doubt of those sentient beings who think: "The bodhisattva arose from the warmth of his father and mother — he was not miraculously born," the bodhisattva enters by passing through his mother's right side. And having entered, there is no wound, no injury to the child; and his mother, the illusory goddess, at that time experiences a bliss such as she had never experienced before.

And why does the bodhisattva's mother grasp a branch of the plakṣa tree, stand upright, and give birth to the bodhisattva in that posture? In order to show ease and comfort to those sentient beings who think: "The illusory goddess gave birth to the bodhisattva with the same painful feelings as any other woman," the bodhisattva's mother grasps a branch of the plakṣa tree, stands upright, and gives birth to the bodhisattva in that way.

And why does the bodhisattva not emerge from another part of the body, nor from the birth canal, but instead pass through his mother's right side, departing from the womb's passage with full mindfulness and full vigilance? Because the bodhisattva lives in purity and is supreme among all three worlds: he does not dwell in the place of birth as others do, and yet he must demonstrate a birth. He is utterly unlike other, ordinary sentient beings. Therefore the bodhisattva emerges from the womb by passing through his mother's right side, and at the very moment of birth there is not even a wound on the flank.

And why is the bodhisattva received immediately at birth by Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods) and not by any other human being? Because the roots of virtue of the bodhisattva blaze with great intensity, and because he had made this aspiration: "May Śakra, lord of the gods, receive me in just this way the very moment I am born."

And why does the bodhisattva, at the very moment of birth, before being received, take exactly seven steps — not six and not eight? Because miracle power, magical display, and the demonstration of something that no holy

person (pudgala) has ever shown before must be displayed, and the purpose for which he takes seven steps cannot be accomplished with six; and were he to take eight, it would be excessive. Therefore the bodhisattva, immediately upon birth, before being received, takes seven steps — not six and not eight.

And why does the bodhisattva, having taken those seven steps, declare in words: "I am foremost in the world; birth, aging, and death I shall bring to their end"? Because in that assembly there are Brahmā and gods of great power who have arrived and are present, and being full of pride they think: "We are the foremost — this one is not," and they do not bow to the bodhisattva, they do not bow with true veneration. Therefore the great bodhisattva thinks to himself: "These brahmās and gods will come before long to have no benefit at all." And for this reason the bodhisattva declares: "I am supreme in the world! I am supreme! Birth and aging and death I shall bring to their end!" — and by that very sound the trichiliocosm (the great thousandfold world-system) is caused to resound. Even those brahmās and gods who had not yet arrived were summoned by that sound. And at that time those brahmās and those sons of the gods joined their palms together and bowed to the bodhisattva. For these reasons of cause and condition, the bodhisattva declares "I am supreme in the world!"

"I am supreme! Birth and aging and death I shall bring to their end!" — these are the words he speaks.

Why does the bodhisattva laugh a great laugh? The bodhisattva does not indulge in frivolous laughter or loud laughter for its own sake. Rather, the bodhisattva thinks to himself: "These sentient beings — had they aroused the awakening mind together with me at that very time, then although I have attained awakening, they have fallen into indolence and wander still in the thick of cyclic existence. Alas! These sentient beings do not apply diligence to the path of liberation that leads to omniscience. Now that they bow down before me, how will they come to apply diligence to omniscience itself?" Arousing great compassion for those who are inferior and those sentient beings who are heedless, and knowing that his own aspirations have been perfectly fulfilled, the bodhisattva laughs a great laugh.

Why does the bodhisattva bathe even though he is without defilement? It is because Śakra (Indra, the king of the gods) and Brahmā have performed acts of veneration. For the bodhisattva must necessarily conform to what the world knows. Having witnessed the birth, the bodhisattva — though indeed without

defilement — must necessarily bathe.

This is the noble Great Vehicle sūtra called the Skillful Means. Second fascicle and last.

Why does the bodhisattva not proceed directly to the seat of awakening immediately upon being born in the grove, but instead re-enters the household? It is in order to show the perfecting of the sense faculties, and to demonstrate playfulness and great sport and the like, and thereby to bring about the going forth from home into homelessness. By demonstrating the renunciation of the four great continents, other disciples who follow him likewise abandon playfulness and great sport and go forth, departing from home into homelessness. For these reasons of cause and condition, the bodhisattva re-enters the household.

Why does the bodhisattva make the time of death occur when he is seven days old and not before? It is the goddess Māyā whose life is exhausted and who makes the time of death occur; there is no fault on the bodhisattva's part. In this matter, the bodhisattva, while still dwelling in the Tuṣita heaven, examines with divine vision the remaining lifespan of the goddess Māyā and knows that ten months and seven days of the goddess Māyā's life remain. After that, the bodhisattva passes away from the Tuṣita heaven and enters his mother's womb. Therefore, by that enumeration as well, it is the goddess Māyā whose life is exhausted and who makes the time of death occur; there is no fault on the bodhisattva's part.

Why does the bodhisattva study the arts and crafts? It is solely in order to conform to the ways of the world. For the bodhisattva, in the great thousandfold world-system of the trichiliocosm, has not failed to have studied from the very beginning every art, every song, every dance, every mantra, every knowledge-mantra, every means, every jest, every game, every sport, every spectacle.

Why does the bodhisattva take a wife? The bodhisattva does not do so out of need for sensual pleasures. Why is that? This noble being is at that time entirely free from desire. Yet it is necessary that the bodhisattva be shown to have been born a male, lest certain sentient beings think: "The bodhisattva was not born male but is by nature a neuter" — and thus their doubt is cut. Furthermore, it is in order to demonstrate the taking of the son Nordzin as an heir. Accordingly, the bodhisattva took as his wife the Śākya maiden Gragsdzin and the others. As for someone who thinks that Nordzin arose from a flame —

that is not how it is to be understood. Nordzin passed away from among the gods and was born here, and thus did not arise from the flame of his parents.

He is to be understood as having been born by miraculous apparitional birth. Moreover, it was through a former aspiration that he took the Śākya maiden Gragsdzin as his wife, for she had made the aspiration: "May I be your wife until the last birth, up to and including the time of Dīpaṃkara." Because the root of virtue she had generated toward the Buddha could not be made to fail, it was for that reason that the Śākya maiden Gragsdzin was taken as his wife.

Furthermore, because these sentient beings are prone to the faults of desire and are attached to domestic affairs, and being unable to renounce these and go forth, it was also for their sake that the bodhisattva, the great being, took on attendants. And the thought would arise in them: "This one has gone forth having abandoned even such an excellent wife and such attendants — why should I not go forth as well?" Moreover, as the bodhisattva was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, those young women whom he had fully ripened, out of love and heartfelt affection, made the aspiration: "May we be your wives until the final existence." And in order to ripen their wholesome qualities still further, the bodhisattva took on attendants. Thus while residing within the women's quarters, he fully ripened forty-two thousand women for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. The remainder he established in possession of the quality of non-falling.

For this reason as well the bodhisattva took on attendants: any woman who was consumed and tormented by the fire of desire — the very moment she saw the bodhisattva, he knew her to be himself free from desire. And the bodhisattva emanated emanations resembling his own reflection in water, and those women sported and took their pleasure with those emanations, thinking to themselves: "We are sporting and taking our pleasure together with the bodhisattva." Yet the bodhisattva, the great being, remained abiding in the joy and bliss of meditative concentration and meditative absorption. The way in which those emanations delighted in and engaged with sensual pleasures is to be understood in the same way for all the enjoyment of sensual pleasures by bodhisattvas up to and including Dīpaṃkara. The groom Chandaka and the horse Kaṇṭhaka likewise are to be understood as arising from former aspirations.

Why did the bodhisattva meditate under the shadow of the rose-apple tree? Because his dwelling there subdued seventy million gods, and it was in order

to demonstrate to his parents that he was certainly going to depart from home.

Why did he go to the pleasure grove? In order to demonstrate old age, sickness, and death. His relatives came to understand that the bodhisattva was going forth from home out of dread and fear of old age, sickness, and death, and not out of any desire to harm them.

Why did the bodhisattva depart from home in the middle of the night and not by day? Because had he remained there, roots of virtue would not have grown, and wishing for wholesome qualities, he was teaching sentient beings: one should depart from there in the middle of the night, without asking permission, abandoning even provisions for travel and for comfort, but one should not abandon the side of wholesome qualities.

Why were the people caused to fall into sleep? Because the gods demonstrated thereby that it was a fault. In order that no seeds of aversion toward the bodhisattva would arise in those people, and so that they would not long suffer harm, be without benefit, and fall into ruin, the gods caused them to sleep. The gods opened the gates, the gods led him through the sky — and it was the gods who

was not a fault of the bodhisattva. Seeing that through this the people would gain the conviction that the great bodhisattva had done no wrong, the gods caused them to fall asleep.

Now, why did the bodhisattva cut his own hair with a sword? Because in the entire great trichiliocosm, there was not a single god, nāga, yakṣa, human, or any other being who could cut the bodhisattva's hair — all were overwhelmed by his glory and majesty. Moreover, so that when King Śuddhodana heard the news and saw that the bodhisattva himself had cut his own hair, he would not be angry, and so that no one would be killed or punished on account of the question "Who has cut my son's hair?" — this was the reason.

Why did the bodhisattva give the horse and the ornaments into the hands of the servant Chandaka? To demonstrate contentment, and to show that the bodhisattva had no desire for gold or silver and went forth into renunciation without regard for any material thing whatsoever.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva needed to train future people: so that those who go forth in this teaching would learn by following his example and, without attachment to any material thing, would dwell in the four noble lineages and

go forth into renunciation — and so that they would not go forth from the very beginning merely for the sake of making a livelihood through the renunciant life.

Now, noble son, hear why the bodhisattva practiced austerities for six years. The bodhisattva did not practice austerities because he was obscured by karma and its faults. Rather, since the bodhisattva was skilled in means, he necessarily had to demonstrate the workings of karma to sentient beings. Noble son, even that occasion when the bodhisattva bowed his head before the scriptures of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened one — the buddha Kāśyapa — and said, "Where is awakening?" — that too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means. It should be understood as intentional speech.

How did the bodhisattva intend it when he spoke those words? Noble son, it was like this: at that time and on that occasion, there were five disciples of the young brahmin Nakṣatrapālita — youths who stood like great śāla trees, abiding in the vehicle of the bodhisattva. Through the influence of evil companions, they had forgotten the awakening mind. Those five noble sons were not practising the discipline of a buddha; instead, holding tīrthika discipline, earnest in tīrthika secret mantras, they claimed for themselves that they too had awakening, and that they too were buddhas, presenting themselves as teachers. Then, recognizing that those five noble sons were now fit vessels, the young Nakṣatrapālita bowed his head and said, "Where is awakening? Awakening is exceedingly rare — seeing that, what can be done?" — and spoke those very words before those tīrthikas. By the young Nakṣatrapālita speaking those words before those tīrthikas — bowing his head and saying, "Where is awakening? Awakening is exceedingly rare" — those five noble sons were gradually brought to complete maturation.

Moreover, noble son, the young Nakṣatrapālita and those five young men were at that time residing together in another region of the earth. Then a potter who was fashioning vessels came to that region of the earth, praising the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened one, the buddha Kāśyapa, and said to Nakṣatrapālita: "Come here! Let us go to the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened one, the buddha Kāśyapa." When those words were spoken, the young Nakṣatrapālita thought to himself: "How wonderful — if the virtuous roots of these sentient beings are fully matured, then if I praise the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened one, the buddha Kāśyapa, and do not

praise the tīrthikas —

— then those young men of good family would become doubtful and unable to come."

And so the young Nakṣatrapālita, keeping to that very first commitment, and with skillful means consonant with the wisdom of the Perfection of Wisdom (prajñāpāramitā), touched the ground with his head in prostration and said these words: "Where is awakening to be found? Awakening is exceedingly rare."

Now, how is it consonant with the wisdom of the Perfection of Wisdom? A bodhisattva engaged in the Perfection of Wisdom does not perceive awakening as an object of perception. There is no perception of a buddha. There is no perception of a buddha's wisdom. Nor is a bodhisattva seen. Awakening is not seen within. Awakening is not seen without. Awakening is not seen within and without together. Thinking thus — "Awakening is utterly empty" — and with no apprehension of any phenomenon whatsoever, the young Nakṣatrapālita, through skillful means, touched the ground with his head and said these words: "Where is awakening to be found? Awakening is exceedingly rare."

Then the young Nakṣatrapālita and those five young men of good family were staying together on the bank of a river. At that point, through the power of the buddha, and in order to bring all five young men of good family to taming, a potter's apprentice seized Nakṣatrapālita by the hair so that he could not go, and took him straight to where the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa was. The five young men, not resisting the potter's apprentice, also went to where the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa was. The moment they beheld the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa, faith arose in them through the stream of their former wholesome roots. Having gained that faith, they reproached the young Nakṣatrapālita, saying: "A Teacher such as this was present, and yet at first you did not lead us here."

Then those five — those brahmins' sons like great śāla trees — seeing the glory, the majesty, and the confidence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa, aroused the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa then, with the sole intent that those five young men of good family

should attain the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena (Skt. anutpattikadharmakṣānti), taught them the Dharma-categories of the irreversible wheel from the scriptural collection of the bodhisattvas.

Now, young man of good family, this is it: I was prophesied by the wisdom of the buddhas.

Young man of good family, had the young Nakṣatrapālita gone ahead and offered praise to the Tathāgata Kāśyapa, those five young men of good family would have had no occasion or opportunity to go to the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Kāśyapa. And so, young man of good family, consider this: although a bodhisattva has no doubt whatsoever regarding buddhas or awakening, in order to bring those five bodhisattvas to full ripening he touched the ground in prostration, consonant with the Perfection of Wisdom, and said these words: "Where is awakening to be found? Awakening is rare." This too should be understood as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Those five bodhisattvas also needed to be brought to ripening, and the ripening of karma needed to be demonstrated as well — and it was for that reason that I undertook ascetic practices. Other sentient beings, not knowing, upon seeing a virtuous ascetic or brahmin endowed with moral discipline would not speak ill of them — whether they knew or did not know. But if such words were spoken, those beings would thereby suffer harm, lack of benefit, discomfort, and suffering for a long time to come.

"They will fall into transgression" — the Tathāgata demonstrates karma in that way in order to show those beings the workings of their own karma. Yet in a bodhisattva there is no karmic obscuration whatsoever.

Furthermore, those who are endowed with moral discipline and who had spoken harsh words, thinking "We have no fortune to be liberated" — dwelling in remorse and no longer striving — so that the doubt of those beings might be dispelled, the bodhisattva, the great being, one birth away from awakening, spoke those same words. And he spoke them so that those beings, recognizing their fault, would think: "If there is fortune for liberation, what need is there to mention that we, who do not know, might also have it?" — and so that others too would not commit that same fault. This too should be understood as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Again, noble son, I practised austerities for six years in order to tame the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), not on account of any obscuration. Ascetics and

brahmins who passed six years eating only single sesame seeds, single grains of rice, and single jujube berries — even so, if the noble path is not attained, purification does not come through wretched food. For that cause and that condition the bodhisattva, the great being, spoke those same words: "Even by merely touching one's head, where is awakening to be found? Awakening is rare." Fixing upon that very activity of karma, he practised those austerities for six years, and by those six years of austerities the bodhisattva achieved the purpose of bringing to gnosis five hundred and twelve million gods and outer sages who had faith in inferior ways. Those too he fully ripened by means of conduct pertaining to the inferior. Noble son, this too should be known as the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Now why did the bodhisattva, rather than going straight away to the seat of awakening, first eat food to generate strength and power? The bodhisattva was indeed capable of fully awakening to complete awakening even without food and with an emaciated body; but the bodhisattva ate food out of compassion for people of future times, so that foolish sentient beings would not seek gnosis while going without food. When hunger afflicts them they cannot accomplish gnosis. Why is that? It is those who are at ease who proclaim the Dharma — not those who are suffering. It was in order that those sentient beings, following in my footsteps, might be brought to ease, that the bodhisattva, the great being, ate food.

The village girl offered food to the bodhisattva in order to fully perfect the factors conducive to awakening. Through eating her food the bodhisattva attained awakening; yet a bodhisattva is capable of remaining in a single meditative absorption for a thousand aeons.

Why did the bodhisattva gather grass? Because the Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas of the past also delighted in a seat spread with grass and did not delight in a prepared throne — and this is to be understood as knowing contentment — and also in order to fully perfect the factors conducive to awakening through that auspicious spread of grass. Therefore, because grass was offered to the bodhisattva, noble son, I have given that person the prophecy that in a future time they will become the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha named Vairocana.

Why did the bodhisattva sit beneath the seat of awakening and not swiftly fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — why did he remain in the face of Māra? Noble son, Māra the evil one finds no occasion and no

opening to approach a bodhisattva who has not himself opened the door and issued an invitation. Even though such an occasion does not exist, noble son, when the bodhisattva, the great being, sat beneath the seat of awakening, he reflected: "Who in this great trichiliocosm — this great three-thousandfold world-system — possesses power? Under whose sway do these sentient beings fall?" And with that thought —

— he saw that these sentient beings were falling under the sway of Māra the evil one. Then the bodhisattva thought: "I myself must do battle with that very one. If he is subdued, the entire desire realm will be subdued. The great divine retinue will also be subdued. And when Māra's host, the yakṣa host, the rākṣasa host, and the nāga host behold this magnificent display of the bodhisattva, they will arouse the mind of awakening and will find faith. Even those who merely hear or see it in the smallest degree will have it as a cause for their complete passage into nirvāṇa." Noble son, the bodhisattva then approached the foot of the tree of awakening, and from the tuft of hair between his brows he sent forth rays of light. With that light he threw into confusion all the dwellings of Māra, and he illuminated every world-system throughout the great trichiliocosm. From those rays of light a sound arose, saying: "This son of the Śākyas, gone forth from home from the Śākya lineage, will fully and completely awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He will lead you beyond your domain. Countless other sentient beings as well he will lead away. Māra's retinue will be left without servants — so go now and engage him in combat!" Noble son, no sooner had that sound been heard than Māra was struck with a great anguish of grief, and at that moment he arrayed a fourfold military force and filled a region of thirty leagues with Māra's army, then advanced to the foot of the tree of awakening. And so the bodhisattva, the great being, abiding in great loving-kindness and with a hand born of the merit of his precious accumulations, defeated Māra's host. Then eighty-four hundred thousand million gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, kinnaras, and great serpents generated the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. That too should be understood as the skillful means of the bodhisattva.

Why did the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, sit cross-legged for seven days without uncrossing his legs or closing his eyes, gazing at the king of trees? The sons of the gods who dwell in the form realm and who move along peaceful paths, on seeing the Tathāgata, the arhat, sitting cross-legged in that place, were greatly delighted. As their delight and

rejoicing arose, they thought: "Let us seek the state in which the mind of the ascetic Gautama is resting." And so for seven days they searched, yet they could not find even a single resting-place of that mind. Then thirty-two thousand sons of the gods generated the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and they resolved: "In a future time, may we too dwell without departing from such a perfectly peaceful manner of conduct and gaze in like fashion at the tree of awakening." For that cause and condition, Tathāgatas who are arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, upon attaining awakening, sit for seven days without uncrossing their legs, without closing their eyes, gazing at the king of trees.

Why, after attaining awakening, do the Tathāgatas who are arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, draw a breath of relief on behalf of countless, immeasurable sentient beings and attend to them with care, yet refrain from teaching the Dharma until requested by Brahmā? In this regard, the Tathāgata reflected thus: "Most gods and humans rely upon Brahmā. They say: 'We are Brahmā's emanations. We are Brahmā's creations.'"

They hold fast to the belief that in the world there is no teacher other than Brahmā. Reflecting on this, the Tathāgata thought: "Those who invoke Brahmā and praise him — when Brahmā himself bows down in reverence, all the gods, humans, and beings who rely upon Brahmā will also bow down in reverence, and they will incline their minds to receive the Dharma. Therefore, the Tathāgata teaches only when requested, and not without a request. Yet through the Tathāgata's own power it is he who summons Brahmā to come and make the request — Brahmā himself has no thought or intention of 'I shall request the Dharma from the Tathāgata.' The Tathāgata summons Brahmā in order that sentient beings who rely upon Brahmā may be freed from that reliance. And when the Great Brahmā requests that the Tathāgata turn the wheel of Dharma, sixty-eight hundred thousand Brahmās, thinking 'This alone is the chief! This alone is the highest!', arouse the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfectly complete enlightenment."

Sons of good family, you should understand the Tathāgata's teaching of the ten karmic threads (Skt. *karmavibhaṅga*) as a matter of skillful means, and recognize it also as a statement of provisional intention. Sons of good family, a bodhisattva who still possesses even a hair-tip's worth of a root of non-virtue has no occasion, no possibility whatsoever, to approach the seat of the tree of awakening. Such a situation simply does not exist.

Sons of good family, the Tathāgata is endowed with all white, virtuous qualities and has abandoned all non-virtuous phenomena. Therefore for the Tathāgata there is no joining with the traces of habitual tendencies, and there is equally no possibility of being harmed by the obscuration of karma. Nevertheless, because there are sentient beings who have thoroughly lost faith in karmic maturation and do not trust in it, the Tathāgata teaches the karmic threads in order to demonstrate karmic maturation to those beings. He teaches them in this way: "I who am the sovereign lord of Dharma — if even I were to experience karmic maturation, how much more must it ripen for you?" Yet in truth, the Tathāgata has not even the slightest obscuration of karma.

Sons of good family, consider this analogy: a teacher who has learned writing and seals, wishing to instruct children, has children enrolled for instruction and then reads out the written primer — though in fact he has no ignorance of it whatsoever, nor does he bear any karmic obscuration. He reads the primer so that the children will hear it from him and learn. Sons of good family, in precisely the same way, the Tathāgata is completely purified of karmic obscuration with respect to all phenomena; yet in order that other sentient beings may likewise become purified of karma, he teaches in that manner and gives that Dharma teaching.

Sons of good family, consider this analogy: a physician who is supremely skilled and who wishes to thoroughly pacify all illness, though himself free of disease, lays out hot and bitter medicines before ailing sentient beings and frees them from their illness. Sons of good family, in exactly the same way the Tathāgata, who is the king of physicians, having himself been freed from all illness and attained unobstructed liberation, teaches karma — "This action, when it ripens, yields this result" — and purposefully displays illness in order to show frightened and terrified sentient beings, those who tremble before their own karma, how body, speech, and mind may become thoroughly purified.

Sons of good family, consider this further analogy: a wet-nurse is engaged by the mother and father of a newly born merchant's son. That wet-nurse, in order to purify the infant's milk, deliberately drinks those medicines — the hot and bitter ones — even though she herself is free of illness.

In just that same way, sons of good family, the Tathāgata — the father of all sentient beings — sees those sentient beings who demonstrate the workings of karma, and, though himself free of illness, displays sickness in order to show them: "This is the karmic ripening of such and such a grave misdeed that

I have committed." Upon hearing this, those sentient beings come to feel a sense of weariness and dismay. Sons of good family, this too should be understood as skillful means.

Sons of good family, in a time long past, there were about five hundred merchants who had entered the great ocean in search of wealth and riches. Among the companions on that voyage there was one who was of evil character, who performed wicked deeds, who was trained in the use of arrows and weapons, who was a thief and a plunderer of others' wealth, and who was traveling in the guise of a merchant. So cunning and ruthless was he that he had boarded that very vessel.

Now that treacherous man thought to himself: "I shall slay all these merchants, take all their wealth, and make for Jambudvīpa." At that time, among the companions aboard the ship, there was a great ship-captain named Great Compassion. And as the captain Great Compassion lay sleeping, the gods dwelling in that great ocean appeared to him in a dream and revealed to him: "Among the companions on this ship there is a deceiver by such and such a name — a plunderer of others' wealth — who intends in his mind to kill all these merchants, take all their wealth, and go to Jambudvīpa. Therefore this man will kill all these merchants. He will commit an unbearable act of wicked karma." Why so? Because those five hundred merchants were bodhisattvas dwelling in unsurpassed perfect awakening (anuttarasamyakṣambodhi) — irreversible bodhisattvas — and if that man were to kill those bodhisattvas, through the fault of that karmic obstruction he would dwell in the great hells for as long as it would take each and every one of those bodhisattvas, one by one, to accomplish unsurpassed perfect awakening. "Therefore," the dream revealed, "think of a method by which this man will not go in that way to the hells, and by which those merchants also will not be killed."

Sons of good family, thereupon the captain thought: "What method can I employ so that these merchants are not killed and this man does not go to the hells?" And saying not a word to anyone else, for seven days he let no wind arise within him, and seven days passed. Then he thought: "There is no other way than to separate this man from his life." And so he reflected: "If I were to inform all the merchants, they would kill him with unwholesome minds, and all of them would come to fall into the hells. But if I myself separate this man from his life — and if on account of that I am born in the hells — I am willing to go on being born in the great hells, life after life, for a hundred thousand aeons, so long as this man does not kill these merchants and thereby accumulate

even greater evil."

Sons of good family, it was thus: the captain Great Compassion, in order to protect those bodhisattvas, deliberately, with that great compassion and that skillful means, killed that man with a weapon's blade. I was at that time the one called the captain Great Compassion.

Sons of good family, it was through that skillful means and that great compassion that I turned my back on cyclic existence for a hundred thousand aeons. And that man, after dying and passing away, was born in the higher realms of the world. As for those five hundred merchants who had boarded the ship, they would later, in the Fortunate Aeon, become five hundred buddhas.

Sons of good family, what do you think? Could there have been even the slightest karmic obscuration in that bodhisattva, that great being, who through the wisdom of skillful means turned his back on cyclic existence for a hundred thousand aeons? Sons of good family, you should not look at it that way. The Tathāgata shows the workings of the karma of sentient beings. Even the thorn of the acacia bush that pierced the foot of the Tathāgata — that too should be understood as the power of the Buddha. Why is that? Although the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha possesses a body like vajra, a body that cannot be penetrated: sons of good family, right here in the great city of Śrāvastī there were twenty men who had reached the last existence of their lives, and those twenty men each had twenty enemies. Then those twenty enemies, thinking to themselves, "We will befriend these men who are our personal foes, go to their homes, and kill them," did so — though none of them spoke a word of this to one another. Sons of good family, then those twenty men who had reached the last existence, together with those who would kill them, were drawn by the power of the Buddha to the very place where the Tathāgata was. Sons of good family, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha then, in order to tame those forty men and to tame the many other beings who were also gathered there, declared to the elder Maudgalyāyana: "Maudgalyāyana, from the great earth a thorn of the acacia bush will arise and it will pierce the right foot of the Tathāgata." Not long after the Tathāgata had spoken those words, in that very instant a thorn of the acacia bush, about an inch in height, arose from the great earth.

Then the venerable Maudgalyāyana said to the Tathāgata: "Blessed One, I will throw this acacia thorn to another world-system." And to this I replied: "Maudgalyāyana, you are not able to do so."

Sons of good family, then the elder Maudgalyāyana, exerting himself to the utmost, grasped the acacia thorn with a force that would have caused this entire great trichiliocosm to tremble violently and shoot upward — yet the acacia thorn did not rise by so much as a hair's breadth. Then the Tathāgata rose up into the Brahma world, and the acacia thorn likewise rose up into the Brahma world. Then the Tathāgata sat down on his seat, and the acacia thorn remained just as before. In the same way, when the Tathāgata took his seat in the middle of the great ocean, the acacia thorn was there as well. Again, when the Tathāgata went to the slope of a mountain, there too the acacia thorn remained. Then the Tathāgata sat down on his seat, and the acacia thorn remained just as before — and then with his right hand the Tathāgata took hold of his right foot and placed it upon the acacia thorn. Then the venerable Ānanda addressed me with these words:

"What karma did the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, formerly perform that this karmic maturation has come about?" I said to him, "Dear one, long ago, when I went to a great ocean port, there was a merchant who was killed by a man named Śhagti with a weapon. This is the remaining karmic maturation of that deed." So he spoke those words.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

There is no place anywhere one can go
where past actions do not catch up with one.
No such region exists — not in mid-air,
not in the middle of the ocean,
not even having entered a mountain cleft.

Son of good family, then those twenty men thought to themselves: "If karmic maturation comes even to the Tathāgata, the lord of Dharma, why should it not come to us?" And so at that time, in the presence of the Tathāgata, the Blessed One, they committed definite killing of living beings, confessed their transgression before the Tathāgata, and performed the disclosure of their fault. So that those forty men might attain gnosis, and so that thirty-two thousand living beings might obtain the stainless and pure eye of Dharma free from defilement — and in order to exhaust karma — the Tathāgata taught the Dharma accordingly, taking karma as his starting point. For that reason and by those conditions, an acacia thorn pierced the foot of the Tathāgata. And yet this was the Tathāgata's skillful means; it was not an obscuration of karma.

Now, why did the Tathāgata, who is free from illness, go to the physician Jīvaka and smell the lotion made from the washing of an utpala flower? At that time, five hundred monks who held the rules of individual liberation, who had not long after their ordination come to be in their final existence — each a common person — were dwelling in a dense forest. They had fallen ill with a disease of such severity that it could not be calmed even by the extraction of medicinal fluids. Out of reverence for the Tathāgata, they sought no other medicine.

Son of good family, then the Tathāgata thought to himself: "Without my giving permission, there is no way for those monks to go in search of other medicine. What means is there for that?" Why so? If the Tathāgata were to give permission, then in later times the noble lineage would thereby degenerate. Therefore, with his skillful means, the Tathāgata went to the physician Jīvaka carrying the lotion made from the washing of an utpala flower. And the gods of the Pure Abode (Śuddhāvāsa) sent word to the monks, saying: "Venerable ones, do not let this be the time of your death — go and seek other medicine." But the monks replied: "We cannot transgress the Tathāgata's training. Even if we should die, we cannot transgress the training of the Tathāgata." So they spoke.

Then those gods of the Pure Abode said to those monks: "Even the Tathāgata himself, the lord of Dharma, has gone seeking other medicine, apart from the extraction of medicinal fluids. Why do you not think to seek it? Venerable ones, go and seek other medicine." So they spoke.

Then those five hundred monks, free from remorse, went in search of other medicine, and through that they were completely freed from their illness. Son of good family, if the Tathāgata had not permitted the seeking of other medicine, there would have been no occasion, no opportunity for those monks to seek other medicine. There would have been no such occasion either for them to be freed from that illness or for them to become arhats. Why then did the Tathāgata — whose merit is entirely and truly exalted — return from entering a village on his alms round just as one would return with a begging bowl that had been washed clean? Although the Tathāgata has no obscuration of karma, the Tathāgata did so in order to protect beings in times to come — for instance, whatever monk, having entered a village and —

— having gone about a town, a palace, or the environs of a royal palace, and finding no alms due to the meagerness of one's own merit — at that moment,

if even the Tathāgata, who has accumulated a store of merit, were to return like one who returns with a begging bowl that has been washed clean, then what need is there to speak of us, who possess only a small root of virtue? We should not be utterly tormented on account of not receiving alms." It was with this consideration in mind, having seen that purpose, that the Tathāgata entered a village and returned like one who returns with a begging bowl that has been washed clean.

Furthermore, one should not view the matter in this way either: that the evil Māra blessed the brahmins and householders so that they would give no alms. Why is that? Māra is incapable of creating an obstacle to the Tathāgata's alms round. Rather, it is through the blessing of the Buddha that Māra blessed the brahmins and householders in that direction. There is not even the slightest obscuration of karma in the Tathāgata. He demonstrates skillful means in order that those sentient beings might be fully ripened.

As for the Tathāgata's going on fast-day, and as for the gods who are Māra, those of Māra's class, and other gods — thinking "perhaps the ascetic Gautama and his śrāvaka disciples are displeased" — they examined day and night the minds of the Tathāgata together with the Saṅgha of śrāvakas, and examined the state of their minds. Yet they did not find even a single mental state of displeasure. There was no puffing up and no bowing down; as it was before, so it was after; as it was after, so it was before.

Then at that time seventy thousand sons of the gods became faithful, prostrated themselves before the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata taught them the Dharma in such a way that all of them without exception obtained the pure Dharma-eye regarding phenomena. This too was the Tathāgata's skillful means; it should be understood that it was not an obscuration of karma.

As for the reason why the girl Ciñcā, tying a wooden bowl to her belly, falsely accused the Tathāgata — there is not the slightest fault of karmic obscuration in the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata, with skillful means, was indeed capable of hurling the girl Ciñcā into as many world-systems as there are grains of sand in the Ganges river; but the Tathāgata, being skillful in means, was demonstrating the working of karma. In this teaching, there are those who will arise and level false accusations against those who have gone forth in renunciation, and they will themselves become false accusers. When they have felt merely the remorse of that false accusation, they may say: "Even against the Tathāgata, who is endowed with all white virtues, a false

accusation arose directly before everyone — why then should it not arise against us?" And at that moment, overwhelmed by the false accusation, they will engage in utterly pure and completely bright holy conduct, and they will not decline.

As for the girl Ciñcā — enveloped by her evil karma, even while dreaming she leveled accusations against the Tathāgata, and immediately upon dying she went to the hell of sentient beings. If the Tathāgata had known that he could protect her, he would have protected her. Why is that? Because the Tathāgata abandons no sentient being whatsoever.

As for the reason why, when the wandering courtesan Sundarī was slain and hidden in the Jeta Grove, the omniscient Tathāgata allowed it to pass without notice — the Tathāgata, being possessed of unobstructed gnosis, knew even that such a thing would come to pass, and the Tathāgata was certainly capable of blessing her so that no weapon would pierce the wandering courtesan Sundarī, and of creating such a miraculous power as would cast her elsewhere. But the wandering courtesan Sundarī's lifespan had come to its end, and she was destined to die;

By that same disposition, knowing that other non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) would be utterly destroyed by their own wrongdoing, and in order that the white, virtuous qualities might increase, the blessing that the Tathāgata bestowed was itself the wisdom of a buddha. For that reason, the Tathāgata did not go into the town for seven days, and in that time tamed sixty million gods. When those seven days had passed, the four-fold assembly came before the Blessed One, and the Tathāgata taught the Dharma to those eighty-four thousand beings in such a way that they would each come to realize gnosis.

As for why the Tathāgata ate barley horse-fodder for three months: the Tathāgata knew full well that these brahmins and householders, having invited him, would fail to keep him in mind — and yet, knowing this, the Tathāgata entered into that situation in accordance with what was fitting. The reason is this: those five hundred horses, at whose fodder the Tathāgata and the community of monks fed for three months, had all in former lives dwelt in the bodhisattva vehicle and had served the Victors of the past. But having fallen under the power of evil companions, they committed evil deeds and were consequently reborn in the animal realm. Among those five hundred horses, the horse called Knowing-the-Finest was himself the bodhisattva named Sūryagarbha. By the power of his aspiration he had taken birth there

purposely, and that bodhisattva Sūryagarbha had set those five hundred horses on the path to awakening and had been born there in order to bring them to complete liberation. Through the power of Knowing-the-Finest, all five hundred horses recalled their previous lives, and by that they turned toward awakening.

Noble son, it was therefore out of compassion for those five hundred horses that the Tathāgata entered into that situation in accordance with what was fitting. From the fodder of Knowing-the-Finest, half was offered to the Tathāgata, and half of the fodder of the five hundred horses was offered to the five hundred monks. Knowing-the-Finest, in horse-language, led those five hundred horses to confess their faults, and caused them to pay homage to the monastic Saṅgha of the Buddha and the others. Thus when the three months had passed, all five hundred horses died at their appointed time, and immediately upon death they were reborn as equals in station among the gods of the Tuṣṭita heaven. Then, having become gods, they made offerings to the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata taught them the Dharma in such a way that they would without fail attain unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And the one among them who had tamed the five hundred horses and kept them alive — him the Tathāgata prophesied would become a pratyekabuddha, a solitary buddha, called Gentle Mind.

Furthermore, noble son, there is not the slightest thing that is less than supreme in the Tathāgata's food. Noble son, even if one were to offer turnips, or wild rice, or bitter herbs, there would be in the great trichiliocosm no taste more exquisite than that — for nothing can become the supreme taste in the way that what arises from turnips, wild rice, and bitter herbs becomes so. Why is this? Because in this way the Tathāgata has attained the major mark of a great being known as "supremely exquisite in taste." Noble son, by that same token it should be understood that all of the Tathāgata's food is supreme.

Noble son, the Elder Ānanda felt compassion upon hearing that the Tathāgata had been fed with the rations of a wheel-turning king, and the Tathāgata, reading his mind, gave him a single grain of barley.

Ānanda asked him, "Do you know what taste this is?" When Ānanda ate it, he was filled with wonder and said to me, "Blessed One, I was born in a royal palace, and having been born in a royal palace, I had never before tasted a supreme flavor such as this." By the power of that grain, the Elder Ānanda was glad and at ease, and seven days passed without his needing any food.

Noble son, through that very account you should understand that the Tathāgata is nowhere obstructed by any karmic obscuration whatsoever. Furthermore, these karmic threads have been shown in order to demonstrate to those sentient beings who invite virtuous renunciants endowed with moral discipline and yet do not give them offerings, that they should act in accordance with what they have said. Noble son, consider the special qualities of the Tathāgata. Even one who invites the Tathāgata and then does not make an offering has been prophesied to be free of any propensity for transgression.

Noble son, among the five hundred monks who had entered the disciplined life together with the Tathāgata, forty monks were engaged in sensual conduct and given to signs of passion. Had those monks consumed that supreme food, extremely passionate thoughts would have arisen in them; but because the food was poor, those thoughts became thin and subtle, and within seven days they attained arhatship.

As for why the Tathāgata, having belched, said, "Kāśyapa, speak now on the branches of awakening" — noble son, it was because hundreds and thousands of divine sons who resided in the vehicle of the hearers had assembled, and previously Kāśyapa had established those divine sons in reliance upon the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Those divine sons had heard teachings on the branches of awakening again and again. Now, had a thousand buddhas taught the Dharma to those divine sons, apart from Kāśyapa, would they have come to understanding? Or rather, because they had no grasping at understanding, Kāśyapa set forth an extensive analysis of the branches of awakening, and those hundreds and thousands of divine sons thereby gained gnosis and understanding. Moreover, there were sentient beings who did not listen to Dharma and did not go to hear Dharma; when those beings heard the Tathāgata, the Dharma-lord himself, proclaim the branches of awakening, they thought, "If those who are ill are completely freed from illness by this, why would we not go to hear the Dharma?" Noble son, therefore, in order to act for the benefit of those divine sons who were to be tamed, and to show the nature of reality to those sentient beings who were ill, the Tathāgata spoke those words — "Having belched, Kāśyapa, speak now on the branches of awakening." That too was the Tathāgata's skillful means; it was not a karmic obscuration.

As for why the Tathāgata said, "When the Śākyas were being destroyed, I felt a pain in my head — it was unbearable" — noble son, in this matter some sentient beings think, "The Tathāgata does not wish for the welfare of his

kinsmen; he does not wish to benefit them; he does not wish them happiness; he does not wish them benefit and happiness — and that is why he let all the royal Śākya lineage perish." But those sentient beings do not know that the Tathāgata brought the mass of beginningless suffering of those kinsmen to an end. In order to protect the minds of those beings who did not know this, the Tathāgata said those words to the Elder Ānanda: "I feel a pain in my head — it is unbearable." Noble son, at the very moment when the Tathāgata spoke those words to the Elder Ānanda — "I feel a pain in my head; it is unbearable" — three thousand divine sons who held nihilistic views, and many sentient beings who took the lives of others, assembled; and those divine sons and those beings —

in order to set those sentient beings on the path of karma, the Tathāgata demonstrated that karmic sequence by saying that what remained of the act of killing had caused the Tathāgata's head to ache. When he demonstrated this, the Tathāgata tamed ten thousand among the divine and human races. And yet that was the Tathāgata's skillful means — it was not a karmic obscuration.

Why, then, did the Tathāgata patiently endure when the brahmin Vāradatta spoke five hundred harsh words against the Tathāgata? Because, although the Tathāgata was incapable of deflecting those harsh words of the brahmin Vāradatta in any other direction, or of producing even a single act of speech in response, many gods and humans had gathered in that assembly, and they saw the Tathāgata cultivating the power of patience. They saw the Tathāgata neither swelled up nor bowed down, possessed of a nature of mental equanimity and ease, his mind stable and his mind perfectly at peace — and seeing this, four thousand living beings aroused the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Seeing that purpose, the Tathāgata remained in equanimity toward the harsh words of the brahmin Vāradatta. In the Tathāgata there is no karmic obscuration whatsoever. That too is the Tathāgata's skillful means — it is not a karmic obscuration.

And as for the fact that Devadatta, in all his future lives, will follow after the great bodhisattva — that too is the bodhisattva's skillful means. Why? Because, through Devadatta, I completed the six perfections and brought benefit to immeasurable sentient beings. How so? Noble son, whenever the bodhisattva made sentient beings happy, at such times Devadatta, not knowing how to give and not knowing how to receive, would come before the bodhisattva and beg for a son, beg for a wife, beg for a kingdom, and beg for

hands, feet, eyes, a head, and whatever else was difficult to give — things that produce the roots of virtue in sentient beings. Having been asked, the bodhisattva, without shrinking, would give. Seeing this, immeasurable sentient beings became joyful and devoted to generosity, making aspirational prayers toward awakening thinking "May we too become like this!" and they would take up moral discipline. And those who wished to tear away moral discipline, seeing the bodhisattva not tearing away his own moral discipline, would cause immeasurable sentient beings to take up moral discipline. Though struck, beaten, or abused, the bodhisattva would not become angry, and through those circumstances beings would come to perfect patience — and through that means, benefit was brought to immeasurable sentient beings.

Moreover, what Devadatta did in preparing to kill the Tathāgata, in sending the intoxicated elephant, and in causing a boulder to come crashing down — all of that too should be understood as the Tathāgata's skillful means; it is not an afflictive karmic obscuration. Why? Because, abiding in this skillful means, benefit was brought to immeasurable sentient beings.

Noble son, to put it briefly: Devadatta, the one who wished to gain fame, is my Teacher. All ten karmic sequences should likewise be understood as the Tathāgata's skillful means. For those sentient beings who, though the ripening of karma is being demonstrated very clearly, do not apply themselves to karmic ripening, the Tathāgata, through his skillful means, demonstrates the karmic sequence by declaring openly: "This is what karmic ripening is! This is what karmic ripening is!" — and upon hearing this, beings come to act for their own benefit. Therefore, noble son, keep this demonstration of skillful means secret. Do not explain it in the presence of sentient beings who possess only meager roots of virtue. Why?

This teaching does not even belong to the ground of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas — how much less, then, to sentient beings who possess only meager roots of virtue. Why? Because those beings have not trained in skillful means, this teaching is simply not for them. Apart from bodhisattvas who are training in this teaching, there is no one else who is a fit vessel for this skillful means.

Consider the following example, noble son: just as when a lamp is lit in the pitch darkness of a moonless night, all the vessels in the house become visible, in exactly the same way a bodhisattva who hears this teaching of skillful means and develops faith in it will come to see all the conduct of a

buddha, and will also teach it to sentient beings.

Noble son, I entrust this to you. Take it deeply to heart. If a noble son or noble daughter who desires awakening, or who possesses skillful means, wishes to let this teaching be heard somewhere, they should travel even a hundred thousand leagues to do so. Why? Because whoever hears this teaching thus set forth will attain illumination, will become free of remorse with respect to all the Dharmas of a buddha, and will become free of doubt.

Thereupon, from among the four assemblies of that world together with its gods, those sentient beings who were fit vessels heard this Dharma discourse. Those who were not fit vessels did not so much as hear it reach their ears. While this Dharma discourse was being expounded, seventy-two thousand living beings gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One and said: "Blessed One, what is the name of this Dharma discourse? How should it be grasped?" The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, retain this Dharma discourse as the Demonstration of the Perfection of Skillful Means, and retain it as the Chapter on the Secret of the Skillful Means of All Buddhas."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words with great joy, Ānanda, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Jñānottara, the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, together with the entire world, rejoiced in what the Blessed One had declared.

The sūtra entitled Skillful Means, a sūtra of the Great Vehicle, is complete. Six hundred ślokas; two bampos.

Translator's Notes

- The name Jñānottara renders the Tibetan Ye shes bla, meaning "Supreme Wisdom" or "Foremost in Wisdom." The Sanskrit reconstruction is conventional; the text gives only the Tibetan form at this point. Some editions read slightly differently, but the sense is consistent.

The phrase rendered "those tiny blossoms not yet gathered up" refers to flowers that remain unclaimed and ownerless — a standard formula in Mahāyāna offering practice for mentally offered gifts requiring no owner's permission.

- The phrase rendered "the Jewel-Handed One" translates an epithet of a Tathāgata described as "phyag na rin chen," literally "jewel in hand." This could refer to Ratnākaraśānti or simply be a descriptive epithet used as an aspirational ideal-image, not necessarily a specific named buddha; the passage is using it as a simile for the aspiration, so "the Tathāgata, the Jewel-Handed One" is the most defensible rendering.

The phrase "rtswa bzhi pa'i tshigs su bcad pa" — rendered here as "a verse on a base" or "a verse on one of the four bases" — is somewhat opaque. The term "rtswa bzhi pa" literally means "fourth base" or "root four," possibly referring to a verse unit within a fourfold scriptural classification. The translation preserves the literal sense without over-interpreting.

- The bodhisattva Jñānottara is the Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit name meaning "one whose gnosis is supreme" or "surpassing wisdom." This is kept as Jñānottara for consistency with standard translations of this text, the Upāyakauśalya Sūtra.

The phrase rendered "eats the root and fruit" refers to the prātimokṣa rule restricting monastics from eating certain plant foods; in context it means he observes the minutiae of monastic discipline scrupulously over vast stretches of time — yet the Blessed One's point, introduced here and presumably completed in the following passage, is that this alone does not constitute the bodhisattva's genuine breach or fulfillment. The sentence is deliberately left open as the Tibetan passage breaks off mid-thought.

- The phrase rendered "the five qualities of the desire realm" translates a term referring to the five objects of sensory enjoyment, a standard technical expression in Mahāyāna literature for the pleasures associated with form, sound, smell, taste, and touch. The juxtaposition of these with the "five faculties of a Tathāgata" is deliberate and doctrinally pointed: outward appearance notwithstanding, the bodhisattva's engagement with sense objects is understood as a display of wisdom and compassion, not ordinary attachment.

The identity of the venerable interlocutor as Ānanda is inferred from the Tibetan honorific "Tshe dang ldan pa Dga' bo," which corresponds to the Sanskrit Āyusmān Nanda or Ānanda. Given the narrative context — alms-round, reporting to the Blessed One, subsequent remorse — the figure is most likely Ānanda, though "Nanda" remains a possibility. This is noted as a genuine uncertainty.

- The Dharma-door phrase "that makes the inner earth element and the outer earth element one and the same" renders a technical meditative teaching on the non-duality of inner and outer earth elements, a theme found in early Mahāyāna sūtras. The precise doctrinal import is clear in context but the exact sūtra from which this passage derives would require further identification.

The name rendered "Free from All Agitation" translates the Tibetan "Kun nas ldang ba dang bral ba," a buddha name found in this prophecy context; the Sanskrit equivalent is not preserved in the passage.

"Tāraka" renders the Tibetan "khye'u skar ma," literally "boy-star" or "star youth"; Tāraka is the conventional Sanskrit reconstruction used in such contexts.

- The name rendered "Gragdzin-ma" is a Tibetan translation of a Sanskrit name (likely Yaśodharā or a similar epithet meaning "bearer of renown"); the text does not preserve a Sanskrit equivalent at this point, and the identification with "Śrāddhinā" in the same passage is uncertain — these may be two different women or the same woman referred to by different names in the narrative continuity. The rendering follows the Tibetan straightforwardly.

The phrase "turned away from and abandoned cyclic existence for ten thousand eons" reflects the Tibetan literally; the doctrinal sense is that the merit of this act of compassion caused the narrator (identified as the future Buddha) to transcend cyclic existence swiftly by that measure of time.

- The final sentence is incomplete in the source passage as given — the Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence with "□□□□□□□□□□" ("has no bow either"), which is clearly the beginning of a longer simile comparing those who do not recognize the skilled bodhisattva's methods to people who misjudge the weapon-master. The translation faithfully renders everything up to

the point where the text ends.

The courtesan simile specifies "sixty-four arts" — this is a standard Indian literary reference to the sixty-four traditional arts a courtesan was expected to master, well attested in Sanskrit literature; no emendation is needed.

- The passage contains the continuation of the analogy of the archer, which was broken mid-sentence in the preceding passage. The transition is smooth: "nor any other weapon..." picks up directly from where the archer's detractors are speaking, consistent with the preceding rendering.

The girl's name, རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་, is rendered "Supreme Merit" as a direct translation. The bodhisattva's name, རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་, is rendered "Joyful" as a direct translation; both are introduced as named characters here for the first time in this passage and are kept consistent with their Tibetan meaning rather than supplied Sanskrit equivalents, since no Sanskrit proper names are attested with certainty in the canonical parallel.

The phrase རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་, literally "having made the time of death," is rendered as "faints" in context, since what follows makes clear she collapses from the intensity of desire — though "dying" in a more literal sense is also defensible. This is a genuine textual ambiguity: if she actually dies, then the bodhisattva's subsequent vision of her is of a corpse, which would align with classical contemplation-of-the-body meditative practice. Either reading supports the doctrinal point that follows.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the final line, which is the beginning of a new verse continuing the divine youth's speech. The passage is rendered as it stands; the continuation belongs to the next passage.

The term rendered "boy" or "divine youth" (lha'i bu) throughout refers to the newly reborn deity who had been the girl Supreme Merit. The shift from "divine maiden" in the birth description to "divine youth" reflects the sex-change at rebirth, which is explicit in the Tibetan and doctrinally significant to the passage's narrative arc.

The phrase "body of luminous birth" translates 'od gsal skyes pa'i lus, literally "a body arisen from luminosity," referring to the self-luminous body characteristic of gods born in the higher realms, not to the technical Vajrayāna "clear light" (though the same term is used).

- The epithet "king of trees" applied to Joyful near the end likely echoes a standard Buddhist metaphor, comparing the bodhisattva's aspiration to the great Śāla or Bodhi tree. The Tibetan "རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་" literally means "king of sap-plants / trees," a recognized poetic epithet for a bodhisattva of supreme stature; it may also carry a specific textual allusion to Mañjuśrī or another figure in the source sūtra, which cannot be determined from this passage alone.

The figure called "Joyful" throughout corresponds to the Tibetan "རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་" and "རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་," meaning "one who makes joyful / delights others." This appears to be a proper name or epithet of the divine youth (son of the gods) whose story is being narrated.

- The phrase rendered "the color of the mind of omniscience" is a somewhat unusual image: just as everything near Meru turns gold, everything that comes near a bodhisattva takes on the hue of the omniscient mind. The Tibetan is clear, though the image is striking and may reflect a specific Sanskrit coinage in the source text.

The tower said to have "risen to the very pinnacle of cyclic existence" is a cosmological hyperbole for something of maximal height, reaching the topmost plane of saṃsāra. This is the intended meaning.

- The phrase rendered "moving forward by means of four sides" translates the Tibetan for "proceeding on four sides" in the context of the raised path — the "four sides" are here

reinterpreted allegorically as the four means of attraction (catvāri saṃgrahavastūni): generosity, kind speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of purpose. This interpretation is standard in Mahāyāna commentarial literature.

The closing phrase "the supremacy of intention" renders Tibetan that literally means something like "an excellent or superior word about intention," which is a slightly unusual construction; it appears to gloss the perfection of patience as rooted in a superior or exalted resolve, and the rendering here follows that sense.

- The bodhisattva name rendered "Jñānottara" translates the Tibetan Ye shes bla, meaning "supreme wisdom" or "wisdom-supreme." This rendering follows the Sanskrit back-formation most naturally suggested by the Tibetan.

The term "head-touching" renders mgo reg, which refers to the famous episode in which the bodhisattva who would become Śākyamuni offered his loosened hair to the buddha Dīpaṃkara (Skt. Dīpaṃkara), who then stepped upon it — an act by which the bodhisattva received the prophecy of his future awakening. The phrase "touching of a head" likely alludes to this event as rendered in one textual version.

The phrase "bound by a single birth" renders skye ba gcig gis thogs pa, the standard expression for a bodhisattva who is one life away from full awakening — equivalent to the Sanskrit ekajātīpratibaddha.

- The four means of gathering disciples refers to the standard Mahāyāna list of the four ways a bodhisattva draws beings in: generosity, pleasant speech, conduct in accordance with the goal, and consistency of word and deed.

The passage describing the bodhisattva's entry into the mother's womb as a white elephant calf alludes to the traditional account of Queen Māyā's dream preceding the birth of Śākyamuni; the text here offers a doctrinal reinterpretation of that narrative as pure symbolic display rather than literal womb-entry.

The final sentence is incomplete in the source text as given; the translation renders all that is present and breaks off at the same point.

- The term rendered "plakṣa tree" translates the Tibetan "shing blag sha," which corresponds to Sanskrit plakṣa, the fig species (Ficus lacor) traditionally associated with Queen Māyā's birth of the Buddha; some editions read śāla or other species, but plakṣa is the philologically supported reading here.

The phrase "the trichiliocosm is caused to resound" renders the standard Buddhist cosmological unit of three thousand great thousands of world-systems, here presented as the field across which the bodhisattva's birth-utterance reverberates, summoning even absent divine beings to witness and pay homage.

- The phrase rendered "arts and crafts" covers a broad range of classical Indian disciplines: the Tibetan lists fine arts, song, dance, mantra, knowledge-mantra, skilled means, jest, game, sport, and spectacle, which are here rendered collectively to preserve the sense of encyclopedic worldly accomplishment.

The name "Nordzin" (Tibetan Nor sbyins) is a Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Yaśodhara in some traditions, though in some tellings it refers to Rāhula or to a different figure. The text names him as the bodhisattva's son and heir. The "flame" reference alludes to a tradition in which Nordzin is said to have arisen miraculously from a flame rather than from ordinary conception; the text here refutes that understanding.

The title line "noble Great Vehicle sūtra called the Skillful Means, second fascicle and last" is a colophon marking the end of the second and final section of the Upāyakauśalya-sūtra.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-clause in the source text, ending with "འགྲོགས་པའི་མཚན་ལས་འགྲོགས་པའི་མཚན་ལས་" which is syntactically incomplete. The translation renders what is present and stops at the same point; the passage clearly continues in the next portion of the manuscript.

The name "Chandaka" is reconstructed from the Tibetan "བླ་མ་བླ་མ་" (bran Tsandaka), which is the standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Chandaka, the name of Siddhārtha's groom.

"Kaṇṭhaka" is likewise standard for "འགྲོགས་པའི་མཚན་ལས་," the name of his horse.

- The passage contains a past-life story framing the bodhisattva's famous question to the buddha Kāśyapa ("Where is awakening?") as intentional speech, a recognized Mahāyāna hermeneutical category. The rendering "intentional speech" for འགྲོགས་པའི་མཚན་ལས་ (literally "words of intended meaning") reflects the standard commentarial sense of *neyārtha* or *abhiprāyika* statements — words whose surface meaning differs from the intended meaning, deployed for a pedagogical purpose. This is a significant doctrinal point worth flagging for the listener who may be unfamiliar with the concept.
- The phrase rendered "touched the ground with his head in prostration" translates the idiom of prostrating by touching one's head to the ground, here used paradoxically — Nakṣatrapālita prostrates while uttering words that seem to deny awakening. This is the key dramatic and doctrinal tension of the passage: his utterance is framed as an act of skillful means consonant with *Prajñāpāramitā* insight, not as genuine denial. The text makes this explicit in the follow-up explanation.

The phrase "irreversible wheel" (*phyir mi ldog pa'i 'khor lo*) refers to the standard Mahāyāna category of Dharma teachings suited to bodhisattvas at the stage of irreversibility; the full term *anutpattikadharmakṣānti*, supplied in parentheses, is the standard Sanskrit for the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena, a landmark attainment on the bodhisattva path.

- The phrase rendered "five hundred and twelve million gods and outer sages" follows the Tibetan "lha dang phyi rol gyi drang srong 'bum phrag lnga bcu rtsa gnyis" literally: fifty-two hundred-thousands (i.e., five million two hundred thousand is one reading; another is fifty-two times one hundred thousand = five million two hundred thousand). The numeral is unusual and the exact figure may depend on the specific recension; the translation renders the Tibetan as given without emendation.

The closing sentence is deliberately left mid-thought, as the Tibetan passage itself ends mid-sentence at that point, continuing into the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "draw a breath of relief and attend to them with care" translates "dbugs phyung zhing gnyer bar byas nas," which is somewhat idiomatic. The first element, "dbugs phyung," literally means "exhaled a breath" and conventionally implies a sigh of relief or compassionate concern; the second, "gnyer bar byas," means to attend to or care for. The overall sense — that the buddhas turn their compassionate attention toward sentient beings before being formally requested to teach — is doctrinally standard and the rendering reflects the received interpretation.
- The phrase "ten karmic threads" renders *las kyi rgyud bcu*. The term *rgyud* here means a continuum or thread of karmic cause-and-effect, likely referring to a known didactic framework of ten karmic actions and their results; the precise text being referenced is not specified in this passage, and the doctrinal content is more important than the exact count, which is presented as a given.

The passage's core argument — that the Tathāgata teaches the karmic threads and displays illness not because he is himself subject to karma or affliction, but purely as skillful means for beings who lack faith in karmic maturation — is a significant doctrinal point deserving

attention: it positions the Buddha's apparent engagement with karmic narrative as entirely pedagogical and intentional, not indicative of any actual karmic residue.

- The seven days during which "no wind arose within him" is a Tibetan idiom meaning the captain revealed nothing to anyone and kept complete silence while deliberating — it carries the sense of suppressing even a breath of speech or action for that period. The rendering preserves this as a natural idiom.

The phrase rendered "let no wind arise within him" could alternatively mean he kept a literal physical fast or stillness, but the commentarial tradition reads it primarily as an idiom for total concealment of his intention. This is noted as a minor but genuine ambiguity.

The story of the ship-captain is a well-known bodhisattva-as-skillful-means narrative found in several Mahāyāna sūtras; the Buddha's self-identification at the close ("I was at that time...") is standard for such jātaka-style passages.

- The text here uses "𑖀𑖩𑖪𑖫𑖬𑖭𑖮𑖯𑖰𑖱𑖲𑖳𑖴𑖵𑖶𑖷𑖸𑖹𑖺𑖻𑖼𑖽𑖾𑗀𑖿𑗁𑗂𑗃𑗄𑗅𑗆𑗇𑗈𑗉𑗊𑗋𑗌𑗍𑗎𑗏𑗐𑗑𑗒𑗓𑗔𑗕𑗖𑗗𑗘𑗙𑗚𑗛𑗜𑗝𑗞𑗟𑗠𑗡𑗢𑗣𑗤𑗥𑗦𑗧𑗨𑗩𑗪𑗫𑗬𑗭𑗮𑗯𑗰𑗱𑗲𑗳𑗴𑗵𑗶𑗷𑗸𑗹𑗺𑗻𑗼𑗽𑗾𑗿𑘀𑘁𑘂𑘃𑘄𑘅𑘆𑘇𑘈𑘉𑘊𑘋𑘌𑘍𑘎𑘏𑘐𑘑𑘒𑘓𑘔𑘕𑘖𑘗𑘘𑘙𑘚𑘛𑘜𑘝𑘞𑘟𑘠𑘡𑘢𑘣𑘤𑘥𑘦𑘧𑘨𑘩𑘪𑘫𑘬𑘭𑘮𑘯𑘰𑘱𑘲𑘳𑘴𑘵𑘶𑘷𑘸𑘹𑘺𑘻𑘼𑘽𑘾𑘿𑙀𑙁𑙂𑙃𑙄𑙅𑙆𑙇𑙈𑙉𑙊𑙋𑙌𑙍𑙎𑙏𑙐𑙑𑙒𑙓𑙔𑙕𑙖𑙗𑙘𑙙𑙚𑙛𑙜𑙝𑙞𑙟𑙠𑙡𑙢𑙣𑙤𑙥𑙦𑙧𑙨𑙩𑙪𑙫𑙬𑙭𑙮𑙯𑙰𑙱𑙲𑙳𑙴𑙵𑙶𑙷𑙸𑙹𑙺𑙻𑙼𑙽𑙾𑙿𑚀𑚁𑚂𑚃𑚄𑚅𑚆𑚇𑚈𑚉𑚊𑚋𑚌𑚍𑚎𑚏𑚐𑚑𑚒𑚓𑚔𑚕𑚖𑚗𑚘𑚙𑚚𑚛𑚜𑚝𑚞𑚟𑚠𑚡𑚢𑚣𑚤𑚥𑚦𑚧𑚨𑚩𑚪𑚫𑚬𑚭𑚮𑚯𑚰𑚱𑚲𑚳𑚴𑚵𑚷𑚶𑚸𑚹𑚺𑚻𑚼𑚽𑚾𑚿𑛀𑛁𑛂𑛃𑛄𑛅𑛆𑛇𑛈𑛉𑛊𑛋𑛌𑛍𑛎𑛏𑛐𑛑𑛒𑛓𑛔𑛕𑛖𑛗𑛘𑛙𑛚𑛛𑛜𑛝𑛞𑛟𑛠𑛡𑛢𑛣𑛤𑛥𑛦𑛧𑛨𑛩𑛪𑛫𑛬𑛭𑛮𑛯𑛰𑛱𑛲𑛳𑛴𑛵𑛶𑛷𑛸𑛹𑛺𑛻𑛼𑛽𑛾𑛿𑜀𑜁𑜂𑜃𑜄𑜅𑜆𑜇𑜈𑜉𑜊𑜋𑜌𑜍𑜎𑜏𑜐𑜑𑜒𑜓𑜔𑜕𑜖𑜗𑜘𑜙𑜚𑜛𑜜𑜝𑜞𑜟𑜠𑜡𑜢𑜣𑜤𑜥𑜦𑜧𑜨𑜩𑜪𑜫𑜬𑜭𑜮𑜯𑜰𑜱𑜲𑜳𑜴𑜵𑜶𑜷𑜸𑜹𑜺𑜻𑜼𑜽𑜾𑜿𑝀𑝁𑝂𑝃𑝄𑝅𑝆𑝇𑝈𑝉𑝊𑝋𑝌𑝍𑝎𑝏𑝐𑝑𑝒𑝓𑝔𑝕𑝖𑝗𑝘𑝙𑝚𑝛𑝜𑝝𑝞𑝟𑝠𑝡𑝢𑝣𑝤𑝥𑝦𑝧𑝨𑝩𑝪𑝫𑝬𑝭𑝮𑝯𑝰𑝱𑝲𑝳𑝴𑝵𑝶𑝷𑝸𑝹𑝺𑝻𑝼𑝽𑝾𑝿𑞀𑞁𑞂𑞃𑞄𑞅𑞆𑞇𑞈𑞉𑞊𑞋𑞌𑞍𑞎𑞏𑞐𑞑𑞒𑞓𑞔𑞕𑞖𑞗𑞘𑞙𑞚𑞛𑞜𑞝𑞞𑞟𑞠𑞡𑞢𑞣𑞤𑞥𑞦𑞧𑞨𑞩𑞪𑞫𑞬𑞭𑞮𑞯𑞰𑞱𑞲𑞳𑞴𑞵𑞶𑞷𑞸𑞹𑞺𑞻𑞼𑞽𑞾𑞿𑟀𑟁𑟂𑟃𑟄𑟅𑟆𑟇𑟈𑟉𑟊𑟋𑟌𑟍𑟎𑟏𑟐𑟑𑟒𑟓𑟔𑟕𑟖𑟗𑟘𑟙𑟚𑟛𑟜𑟝𑟞𑟟𑟠𑟡𑟢𑟣𑟤𑟥𑟦𑟧𑟨𑟩𑟪𑟫𑟬𑟭𑟮𑟯𑟰𑟱𑟲𑟳𑟴𑟵𑟶𑟷𑟸𑟹𑟺𑟻𑟼𑟽𑟾𑟿𑠀𑠁𑠂𑠃𑠄𑠅𑠆𑠇𑠈𑠉𑠊𑠋𑠌𑠍𑠎𑠏𑠐𑠑𑠒𑠓𑠔𑠕𑠖𑠗𑠘𑠙𑠚𑠛𑠜𑠝𑠞𑠟𑠠𑠡𑠢𑠣𑠤𑠥𑠦𑠧𑠨𑠩𑠪𑠫𑠬𑠭𑠮𑠯𑠰𑠱𑠲𑠳𑠴𑠵𑠶𑠷𑠸𑠺𑠹𑠻𑠼𑠽𑠾𑠿𑡀𑡁𑡂𑡃𑡄𑡅𑡆𑡇𑡈𑡉𑡊𑡋𑡌𑡍𑡎𑡏𑡐𑡑𑡒𑡓𑡔𑡕𑡖𑡗𑡘𑡙𑡚𑡛𑡜𑡝𑡞𑡟𑡠𑡡𑡢𑡣𑡤𑡥𑡦𑡧𑡨𑡩𑡪𑡫𑡬𑡭𑡮𑡯𑡰𑡱𑡲𑡳𑡴𑡵𑡶𑡷𑡸𑡹𑡺𑡻𑡼𑡽𑡾𑡿𑢀𑢁𑢂𑢃𑢄𑢅𑢆𑢇𑢈𑢉𑢊𑢋𑢌𑢍𑢎𑢏𑢐𑢑𑢒𑢓𑢔𑢕𑢖𑢗𑢘𑢙𑢚𑢛𑢜𑢝𑢞𑢟𑢠𑢡𑢢𑢣𑢤𑢥𑢦𑢧𑢨𑢩𑢪𑢫𑢬𑢭𑢮𑢯𑢰𑢱𑢲𑢳𑢴𑢵𑢶𑢷𑢸𑢹𑢺𑢻𑢼𑢽𑢾𑢿𑣀𑣁𑣂𑣃𑣄𑣅𑣆𑣇𑣈𑣉𑣊𑣋𑣌𑣍𑣎𑣏𑣐𑣑𑣒𑣓𑣔𑣕𑣖𑣗𑣘𑣙𑣚𑣛𑣜𑣝𑣞𑣟𑣠𑣡𑣢𑣣𑣤𑣥𑣦𑣧𑣨𑣩𑣪𑣫𑣬𑣭𑣮𑣯𑣰𑣱𑣲𑣳𑣴𑣵𑣶𑣷𑣸𑣹𑣺𑣻𑣼𑣽𑣾𑣿𑤀𑤁𑤂𑤃𑤄𑤅𑤆𑤇𑤈𑤉𑤊𑤋𑤌𑤍𑤎𑤏𑤐𑤑𑤒𑤓𑤔𑤕𑤖𑤗𑤘𑤙𑤚𑤛𑤜𑤝𑤞𑤟𑤠𑤡𑤢𑤣𑤤𑤥𑤦𑤧𑤨𑤩𑤪𑤫𑤬𑤭𑤮𑤯𑤰𑤱𑤲𑤳𑤴𑤵𑤶𑤷𑤸𑤹𑤺𑤻𑤼𑤽𑤾𑤿𑥀𑥁𑥂𑥃𑥄𑥅𑥆𑥇𑥈𑥉𑥊𑥋𑥌𑥍𑥎𑥏𑥐𑥑𑥒𑥓𑥔𑥕𑥖𑥗𑥘𑥙𑥚𑥛𑥜𑥝𑥞𑥟𑥠𑥡𑥢𑥣𑥤𑥥𑥦𑥧𑥨𑥩𑥪𑥫𑥬𑥭𑥮𑥯𑥰𑥱𑥲𑥳𑥴𑥵𑥶𑥷𑥸𑥹𑥺𑥻𑥼𑥽𑥾𑥿𑦀𑦁𑦂𑦃𑦄𑦅𑦆𑦇𑦈𑦉𑦊𑦋𑦌𑦍𑦎𑦏𑦐𑦑𑦒𑦓𑦔𑦕𑦖𑦗𑦘𑦙𑦚𑦛𑦜𑦝𑦞𑦟𑦠𑦡𑦢𑦣𑦤𑦥𑦦𑦧𑦨𑦩𑦪𑦫𑦬𑦭𑦮𑦯𑦰𑦱𑦲𑦳𑦴𑦵𑦶𑦷𑦸𑦹𑦺𑦻𑦼𑦽𑦾𑦿𑧀𑧁𑧂𑧃𑧄𑧅𑧆𑧇𑧈𑧉𑧊𑧋𑧌𑧍𑧎𑧏𑧐𑧑𑧒𑧓𑧔𑧕𑧖𑧗𑧘𑧙𑧚𑧛𑧜𑧝𑧞𑧟𑧠𑧡𑧢𑧣𑧤𑧥𑧦𑧧𑧨𑧩𑧪𑧫𑧬𑧭𑧮𑧯𑧰𑧱𑧲𑧳𑧴𑧵𑧶𑧷𑧸𑧹𑧺𑧻𑧼𑧽𑧾𑧿𑨀𑨁𑨂𑨃𑨄𑨅𑨆𑨇𑨈𑨉𑨊𑨋𑨌𑨍𑨎𑨏𑨐𑨑𑨒𑨓𑨔𑨕𑨖𑨗𑨘𑨙𑨚𑨛𑨜𑨝𑨞𑨟𑨠𑨡𑨢𑨣𑨤𑨥𑨦𑨧𑨨𑨩𑨪𑨫𑨬𑨭𑨮𑨯𑨰𑨱𑨲𑨳𑨴𑨵𑨶𑨷𑨸𑨹𑨺𑨻𑨼𑨽𑨾𑨿𑩀𑩁𑩂𑩃𑩄𑩅𑩆𑩇𑩈𑩉𑩊𑩋𑩌𑩍𑩎𑩏𑩐𑩑𑩒𑩓𑩔𑩕𑩖𑩗𑩘𑩙𑩚𑩛𑩜𑩝𑩞𑩟𑩠𑩡𑩢𑩣𑩤𑩥𑩦𑩧𑩨𑩩𑩪𑩫𑩬𑩭𑩮𑩯𑩰𑩱𑩲𑩳𑩴𑩵𑩶𑩷𑩸𑩹𑩺𑩻𑩼𑩽𑩾𑩿𑪀𑪁𑪂𑪃𑪄𑪅𑪆𑪇𑪈𑪉𑪊𑪋𑪌𑪍𑪎𑪏𑪐𑪑𑪒𑪓𑪔𑪕𑪖𑪗𑪘𑪙𑪚𑪛𑪜𑪝𑪞𑪟𑪠𑪡𑪢𑪣𑪤𑪥𑪦𑪧𑪨𑪩𑪪𑪫𑪬𑪭𑪮𑪯𑪰𑪱𑪲𑪳𑪴𑪵𑪶𑪷𑪸𑪹𑪺𑪻𑪼𑪽𑪾𑪿𑫀𑫁𑫂𑫃𑫄𑫅𑫆𑫇𑫈𑫉𑫊𑫋𑫌𑫍𑫎𑫏𑫐𑫑𑫒𑫓𑫔𑫕𑫖𑫗𑫘𑫙𑫚𑫛𑫜𑫝𑫞𑫟𑫠𑫡𑫢𑫣𑫤𑫥𑫦𑫧𑫨𑫩𑫪𑫫𑫬𑫭𑫮𑫯𑫰𑫱𑫲𑫳𑫴𑫵𑫶𑫷𑫸𑫹𑫺𑫻𑫼𑫽𑫾𑫿𑬀𑬁𑬂𑬃𑬄𑬅𑬆𑬇𑬈𑬉𑬊𑬋𑬌𑬍𑬎𑬏𑬐𑬑𑬒𑬓𑬔𑬕𑬖𑬗𑬘𑬙𑬚𑬛𑬜𑬝𑬞𑬟𑬠𑬡𑬢𑬣𑬤𑬥𑬦𑬧𑬨𑬩𑬪𑬫𑬬𑬭𑬮𑬯𑬰𑬱𑬲𑬳𑬴𑬵𑬶𑬷𑬸𑬹𑬺𑬻𑬼𑬽𑬾𑬿𑭀𑭁𑭂𑭃𑭄𑭅𑭆𑭇𑭈𑭉𑭊𑭋𑭌𑭍𑭎𑭏𑭐𑭑𑭒𑭓𑭔𑭕𑭖𑭗𑭘𑭙𑭚𑭛𑭜𑭝𑭞𑭟𑭠𑭡𑭢𑭣𑭤𑭥𑭦𑭧𑭨𑭩𑭪𑭫𑭬𑭭𑭮𑭯𑭰𑭱𑭲𑭳𑭴𑭵𑭶𑭷𑭸𑭹𑭺𑭻𑭼𑭽𑭾𑭿𑮀𑮁𑮂𑮃𑮄𑮅𑮆𑮇𑮈𑮉𑮊𑮋𑮌𑮍𑮎𑮏𑮐𑮑𑮒𑮓𑮔𑮕𑮖𑮗𑮘𑮙𑮚𑮛𑮜𑮝𑮞𑮟𑮠𑮡𑮢𑮣𑮤𑮥𑮦𑮧𑮨𑮩𑮪𑮫𑮬𑮭𑮮𑮯𑮰𑮱𑮲𑮳𑮴𑮵𑮶𑮷𑮸𑮹𑮺𑮻𑮼𑮽𑮾𑮿𑯀𑯁𑯂𑯃𑯄𑯅𑯆𑯇𑯈𑯉𑯊𑯋𑯌𑯍𑯎𑯏𑯐𑯑𑯒𑯓𑯔𑯕𑯖𑯗𑯘𑯙𑯚𑯛𑯜𑯝𑯞𑯟𑯠𑯡𑯢𑯣𑯤𑯥𑯦𑯧𑯨𑯩𑯪𑯫𑯬𑯭𑯮𑯯𑯰𑯱𑯲𑯳𑯴𑯵𑯶𑯷𑯸𑯹𑯺𑯻𑯼𑯽𑯾𑯿𑰀𑰁𑰂𑰃𑰄𑰅𑰆𑰇𑰈𑰉𑰊𑰋𑰌𑰍𑰎𑰏𑰐𑰑𑰒𑰓𑰔𑰕𑰖𑰗𑰘𑰙𑰚𑰛𑰜𑰝𑰞𑰟𑰠𑰡𑰢𑰣𑰤𑰥𑰦𑰧𑰨𑰩𑰪𑰫𑰬𑰭𑰮𑰯𑰰𑰱𑰲𑰳𑰴𑰵𑰶𑰷𑰸𑰹𑰺𑰻𑰼𑰽𑰾𑰿𑱀𑱁𑱂𑱃𑱄𑱅𑱆𑱇𑱈𑱉𑱊𑱋𑱌𑱍𑱎𑱏𑱐𑱑𑱒𑱓𑱔𑱕𑱖𑱗𑱘𑱙𑱚𑱛𑱜𑱝𑱞𑱟𑱠𑱡𑱢𑱣𑱤𑱥𑱦𑱧𑱨𑱩𑱪𑱫𑱬𑱭𑱮𑱯𑱰𑱱𑱲𑱳𑱴𑱵𑱶𑱷𑱸𑱹𑱺𑱻𑱼𑱽𑱾𑱿𑲀𑲁𑲂𑲃𑲄𑲅𑲆𑲇𑲈𑲉𑲊𑲋𑲌𑲍𑲎𑲏𑲐𑲑𑲒𑲓𑲔𑲕𑲖𑲗𑲘𑲙𑲚𑲛𑲜𑲝𑲞𑲟𑲠𑲡𑲢𑲣𑲤𑲥𑲦𑲧𑲨𑲩𑲪𑲫𑲬𑲭𑲮𑲯𑲰𑲱𑲲𑲳𑲴𑲵𑲶𑲷𑲸𑲹𑲺𑲻𑲼𑲽𑲾𑲿𑳀𑳁𑳂𑳃𑳄𑳅𑳆𑳇𑳈𑳉𑳊𑳋𑳌𑳍𑳎𑳏𑳐𑳑𑳒𑳓𑳔𑳕𑳖𑳗𑳘𑳙𑳚𑳛𑳜𑳝𑳞𑳟𑳠𑳡𑳢𑳣𑳤𑳥𑳦𑳧𑳨𑳩𑳪𑳫𑳬𑳭𑳮𑳯𑳰𑳱𑳲𑳳𑳴𑳵𑳶𑳷𑳸𑳹𑳺𑳻𑳼𑳽𑳾𑳿𑴀𑴁𑴂𑴃𑴄𑴅𑴆𑴇𑴈𑴉𑴊𑴋𑴌𑴍𑴎𑴏𑴐𑴑𑴒𑴓𑴔𑴕𑴖𑴗𑴘𑴙𑴚𑴛𑴜𑴝𑴞𑴟𑴠𑴡𑴢𑴣𑴤𑴥𑴦𑴧𑴨𑴩𑴪𑴫𑴬𑴭𑴮𑴯𑴰𑴱𑴲𑴳𑴴𑴵𑴶𑴷𑴸𑴹𑴺𑴻𑴼𑴽𑴾𑴿𑵀𑵁𑵂𑵃𑵄𑵅𑵆𑵇𑵈𑵉𑵊𑵋𑵌𑵍𑵎𑵏𑵐𑵑𑵒𑵓𑵔𑵕𑵖𑵗𑵘𑵙𑵚𑵛𑵜𑵝𑵞𑵟𑵠𑵡𑵢𑵣𑵤𑵥𑵦𑵧𑵨𑵩𑵪𑵫𑵬𑵭𑵮𑵯𑵰𑵱𑵲𑵳𑵴𑵵𑵶𑵷𑵸𑵹𑵺𑵻𑵼𑵽𑵾𑵿𑶀𑶁𑶂𑶃𑶄𑶅𑶆𑶇𑶈𑶉𑶊𑶋𑶌𑶍𑶎𑶏𑶐𑶑𑶒𑶓𑶔𑶕𑶖𑶗𑶘𑶙𑶚𑶛𑶜𑶝𑶞𑶟𑶠𑶡𑶢𑶣𑶤𑶥𑶦𑶧𑶨𑶩𑶪𑶫𑶬𑶭𑶮𑶯𑶰𑶱𑶲𑶳𑶴𑶵𑶶𑶷𑶸𑶹𑶺𑶻𑶼𑶽𑶾𑶿𑷀𑷁𑷂𑷃𑷄𑷅𑷆𑷇𑷈𑷉𑷊𑷋𑷌𑷍𑷎𑷏𑷐𑷑𑷒𑷓𑷔𑷕𑷖𑷗𑷘𑷙𑷚𑷛𑷜𑷝𑷞𑷟𑷠𑷡𑷢𑷣𑷤𑷥𑷦𑷧𑷨𑷩𑷪𑷫𑷬𑷭𑷮𑷯𑷰𑷱𑷲𑷳𑷴𑷵𑷶𑷷𑷸𑷹𑷺𑷻𑷼𑷽𑷾𑷿𑸀𑸁𑸂𑸃𑸄𑸅𑸆𑸇𑸈𑸉𑸊𑸋𑸌𑸍𑸎𑸏𑸐𑸑𑸒𑸓𑸔𑸕𑸖𑸗𑸘𑸙𑸚𑸛𑸜𑸝𑸞𑸟𑸠𑸡𑸢𑸣𑸤𑸥𑸦𑸧𑸨𑸩𑸪𑸫𑸬𑸭𑸮𑸯𑸰𑸱𑸲𑸳𑸴𑸵𑸶𑸷𑸸𑸹𑸺𑸻𑸼𑸽𑸾𑸿𑹀𑹁𑹂𑹃𑹄𑹅𑹆𑹇𑹈𑹉𑹊𑹋𑹌𑹍𑹎𑹏𑹐𑹑𑹒𑹓𑹔𑹕𑹖𑹗𑹘𑹙𑹚𑹛𑹜𑹝𑹞𑹟𑹠𑹡𑹢𑹣𑹤𑹥𑹦𑹧𑹨𑹩𑹪𑹫𑹬𑹭𑹮𑹯𑹰𑹱𑹲𑹳𑹴𑹵𑹶𑹷𑹸𑹹𑹺𑹻𑹼𑹽𑹾𑹿𑺀𑺁𑺂𑺃𑺄𑺅𑺆𑺇𑺈𑺉𑺊𑺋𑺌𑺍𑺎𑺏𑺐𑺑𑺒𑺓𑺔𑺕𑺖𑺗𑺘𑺙𑺚𑺛𑺜𑺝𑺞𑺟𑺠𑺡𑺢𑺣𑺤𑺥𑺦𑺧𑺨𑺩𑺪𑺫𑺬𑺭𑺮𑺯𑺰𑺱𑺲𑺳𑺴𑺵𑺶𑺷𑺸𑺹𑺺𑺻𑺼𑺽𑺾𑺿𑻀𑻁𑻂𑻃𑻄𑻅𑻆𑻇𑻈𑻉𑻊𑻋𑻌𑻍𑻎𑻏𑻐𑻑𑻒𑻓𑻔𑻕𑻖𑻗𑻘𑻙𑻚𑻛𑻜𑻝𑻞𑻟𑻠𑻡𑻢𑻣𑻤𑻥𑻦𑻧𑻨𑻩𑻪𑻫𑻬𑻭𑻮𑻯𑻰𑻱𑻲𑻳𑻴𑻵𑻶𑻷𑻸𑻹𑻺𑻻𑻼𑻽𑻾𑻿𑼀𑼁𑼂𑼃𑼄𑼅𑼆𑼇𑼈𑼉𑼊𑼋𑼌𑼍𑼎𑼏𑼐𑼑𑼒𑼓𑼔𑼕𑼖𑼗𑼘𑼙𑼚𑼛𑼜𑼝𑼞𑼟𑼠𑼡𑼢𑼣𑼤𑼥𑼦𑼧𑼨𑼩𑼪𑼫𑼬𑼭𑼮𑼯𑼰𑼱𑼲𑼳𑼴𑼵𑼶𑼷𑼸𑼹𑼺𑼻𑼼𑼽𑼾𑼿𑽀𑽁𑽂𑽃𑽄𑽅𑽆𑽇𑽈𑽉𑽊𑽋𑽌𑽍𑽎𑽏𑽐𑽑𑽒𑽓𑽔𑽕𑽖𑽗𑽘𑽙𑽚𑽛𑽜𑽝𑽞𑽟𑽠𑽡𑽢𑽣𑽤𑽥𑽦𑽧𑽨𑽩𑽪𑽫𑽬𑽭𑽮𑽯𑽰𑽱𑽲𑽳𑽴𑽵𑽶𑽷𑽸𑽹𑽺𑽻𑽼𑽽𑽾𑽿𑾀𑾁𑾂𑾃𑾄𑾅𑾆𑾇𑾈𑾉𑾊𑾋𑾌𑾍𑾎𑾏𑾐𑾑𑾒𑾓𑾔𑾕𑾖𑾗𑾘𑾙𑾚𑾛𑾜𑾝𑾞𑾟𑾠𑾡𑾢𑾣𑾤𑾥𑾦𑾧𑾨𑾩𑾪𑾫𑾬𑾭𑾮𑾯𑾰𑾱𑾲𑾳𑾴𑾵𑾶𑾷𑾸𑾹𑾺𑾻𑾼𑾽𑾾𑾿𑿀𑿁𑿂𑿃𑿄𑿅𑿆𑿇𑿈𑿉𑿊𑿋𑿌𑿍𑿎𑿏𑿐𑿑𑿒𑿓𑿔𑿕𑿖𑿗𑿘𑿙𑿚𑿛𑿜𑿝𑿞𑿟𑿠𑿡𑿢𑿣𑿤𑿥𑿦𑿧𑿨𑿩𑿪𑿫𑿬𑿭𑿮𑿯𑿰𑿱𑿲𑿳𑿴𑿵𑿶𑿷𑿸𑿹𑿺𑿻𑿼𑿽𑿾𑿿𑀀𑀁𑀂𑀃𑀄𑀅𑀆𑀇𑀈𑀉𑀊𑀋𑀌𑀍𑀎𑀏𑀐𑀑𑀒𑀓𑀔𑀕𑀖𑀗𑀘𑀙𑀚𑀛𑀜𑀝𑀞𑀟𑀠𑀡𑀢𑀣𑀤𑀥𑀦𑀧𑀨𑀩𑀪𑀫𑀬𑀭𑀮𑀯𑀰𑀱𑀲𑀳𑀴𑀵𑀶𑀷𑀸𑀹𑀺𑀻𑀼𑀽𑀾𑀿𑁀𑁁𑁂𑁃𑁄𑁅𑁆𑁇𑁈𑁉𑁊𑁋𑁌𑁍𑁎𑁏𑁐𑁑𑁒𑁓𑁔𑁕𑁖𑁗𑁘𑁙𑁚𑁛𑁜𑁝𑁞𑁟𑁠𑁡𑁢𑁣𑁤𑁥𑁦𑁧𑁨𑁩𑁪𑁫𑁬𑁭𑁮𑁯𑁰𑁱𑁲𑁳𑁴𑁵𑁶𑁷𑁸𑁹𑁺𑁻𑁼𑁽𑁾𑁿𑂀𑂁𑂂𑂃𑂄𑂅𑂆𑂇𑂈𑂉𑂊𑂋𑂌𑂍𑂎𑂏𑂐𑂑𑂒𑂓𑂔𑂕𑂖𑂗𑂘𑂙𑂚𑂛𑂜𑂝𑂞𑂟𑂠𑂡𑂢𑂣𑂤𑂥𑂦𑂧𑂨𑂩𑂪𑂫𑂬𑂭𑂮𑂯𑂰𑂱𑂲𑂳𑂴𑂵𑂶𑂷𑂸𑂺𑂹𑂻𑂼𑂽𑂾𑂿𑃀𑃁𑃂𑃃𑃄𑃅𑃆𑃇𑃈𑃉𑃊𑃋𑃌𑃍𑃎𑃏𑃐𑃑𑃒𑃓𑃔𑃕𑃖𑃗𑃘𑃙𑃚𑃛𑃜𑃝𑃞𑃟𑃠𑃡𑃢𑃣𑃤𑃥𑃦𑃧𑃨𑃩𑃪𑃫𑃬𑃭𑃮𑃯𑃰𑃱𑃲𑃳𑃴𑃵𑃶𑃷𑃸𑃹𑃺𑃻𑃼𑃽𑃾𑃿𑄀𑄁𑄂𑄃𑄄𑄅𑄆𑄇𑄈𑄉𑄊𑄋𑄌𑄍𑄎𑄏𑄐𑄑𑄒𑄓𑄔𑄕𑄖𑄗𑄘𑄙𑄚𑄛𑄜𑄝𑄞𑄟𑄠𑄡𑄢𑄣𑄤𑄥𑄦𑄧𑄨𑄩𑄪𑄫𑄬𑄭𑄮𑄯𑄰𑄱𑄲𑄳𑄴𑄵𑄶𑄷𑄸𑄹𑄺𑄻𑄼𑄽𑄾𑄿𑅀𑅁𑅂𑅃𑅄𑅅𑅆𑅇𑅈𑅉𑅊𑅋𑅌𑅍𑅎𑅏𑅐𑅑𑅒𑅓𑅔𑅕𑅖𑅗𑅘𑅙𑅚𑅛𑅜𑅝𑅞𑅟𑅠𑅡𑅢

illustrative accounts of karma have been presented pedagogically.

The passage describing the forty monks and poor food leading to arhatship presents a doctrinal point about how inferior food reduced the intensity of passionate thoughts, thereby facilitating liberation — a teaching found in several karmic-story collections and consistent with Abhidharma analysis of the relationship between physical conditions and mental states.

The final sentence is incomplete in the source passage, cutting off mid-narrative, which is reflected in the translation.

- The passage states that Devadatta is the Buddha's "Teacher" — this is a deliberate doctrinal paradox: because Devadatta's provocations were the occasion for the bodhisattva's perfection of patience and generosity, Devadatta functions as a teacher in a functional, not honorific, sense. The Tibetan is unambiguous and the translation preserves it without softening.

The term rendered "ten karmic sequences" refers to a set of ten karmic narratives or episodes involving the Tathāgata that have been enumerated earlier in the sūtra; the number is taken from the Tibetan as given.

- The name "Jñānottara" renders the Tibetan Ye shes bla, literally "wisdom supreme" or "wisdom surpassing." This appears to be a bodhisattva figure within the text's assembly rather than a widely attested independent figure; the Sanskrit reconstruction is regular but not independently confirmed from this passage alone.

The phrase rendered "a moonless night" renders sa sros pa'i mun pa, literally "darkness of a night with frost on the ground" or "a frost-dark night," indicating a particularly dark, overcast night. The translation conveys the intended sense of total darkness without introducing distracting literalism for a listening audience.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.